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TRINAMOOL ROW

Factions barred from using name, symbol

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PM pitches India as hub for chipmaking

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Qualifying percentile will be cut to 30: govt.

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PARLEY

Does BRICS meet signify a foreign policy shift?

Delhi declaration slams western sanctions, Israel

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DOMINANT DISPLAY

Abhishek dazzles as India sweeps series

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NEARBY



UN experts cite possible U.S. war crimes in Iran

GENEVA

Human rights experts commissioned by the UN's top human rights body say they have found "reasonable grounds" to believe the U.S. committed war crimes in two strikes in Iran, including on a school in Minab. » PAGE 14

Change mindset on Hindi use, SC tells Tamil Nadu

NEW DELHI

While hearing a case on adoption of the Navodaya Vidyalaya Scheme in Tamil Nadu, the Supreme Court said that the State has to change the "mindset" that Hindi cannot be taught on the soil of the State. » PAGE 3

'Stem cell therapy for autism only in approved trials'

NEW DELHI

The Union Health Ministry has asked States and Union Territories to ensure that the use of stem cell therapy for Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD) is restricted to duly approved clinical trials. » PAGE 6

SC calls for report on 25 unnatural deaths in Manipur

NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court ordered the Manipur Chief Secretary to submit a detailed report on 25 unnatural deaths reported among internally displaced persons in relief camps across the State. » PAGE 5

Declared dead, 2,500 Odisha workers return for ration

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

In a bid to hoodwink Odisha's welfare machinery, almost 2,500 construction workers appear to have defied the rules of mortality – they died on paper, collected death benefits, and then came back to life to authenticate their Aadhaar and collect their monthly ration.

An audit has blown the lid off what appears to be a bizarre and massive fraud under the State's Nirman Shramik welfare scheme.

As many as 2,487 construction workers were declared dead and their nominees were paid death assistance, even though the workers continued to draw subsidised food grains under the National Food Security Act (NFSA) and State Food Security Scheme after their record-



ILLUSTRATION:
SOUMYADIP SINHA

ed deaths. The contradiction becomes even more startling in 753 cases.

The audit found that these beneficiaries authenticated their Aadhaar biometrically to obtain ration after they had officially been declared dead. Death assistance amounting to ₹15.10 crore was subsequently paid to their nominees.

In other words, the go-

vernment's records had buried the workers, while its ration system was still recognising their fingerprints.

Audit report

This damning indictment, found in the draft information system audit report on 'Implementation of PA-ResHRAM and Nirman Shramik Portal in the State', is expected to be

part of the Comptroller and Auditor General's Audit report for the financial year 2024-2025.

"This implies the beneficiary was alive and authenticating her Aadhaar physically to avail ration indicating fraudulent disbursement of death benefit. Further, it also indicates that medical officers issued death certificates against alive persons," the draft report says.

Subu R., the Principal Accountant General (Audit-I) of Odisha, had sent the draft report to Chithra Arumugam, then Additional Chief Secretary to the Labour and ESI Department, soliciting her response on the massive anomalies indicating corruption in the implementation of the Nirman Shramik scheme. A copy of the draft report has been obtained by *The Hindu*.

Under the Nirman Shramik scheme, building and construction workers between ages of 18 and 60 who have completed at least 90 days of work in the preceding 12 months and are not enrolled in any other welfare fund are eligible for registration under the Building and Other Construction Workers (Regulation of Employment and Conditions of Service) Act, 1996.

Various benefits

Once registered, workers are entitled to various welfare benefits including educational scholarships for their children, assistance for marriage, maternity, and funeral expenses, and death compensation. A nominee is entitled to ₹2 lakh as a death benefit and ₹5,000 as funeral assistance upon the death of an eligible registered worker.

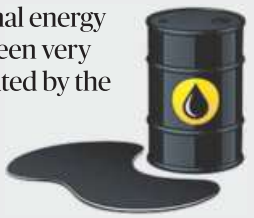
Who are the targets?

The Bill aims to dissuade countries from 'aiding Russian aggression' against Ukraine by purchasing Russian oil and gas

The Bill targets top five "largest importers, by total volume" in the 12 months preceding the date of enactment of the law, which have knowingly made new purchases on or after 30 days from the date the Bill becomes law

This issue has been discussed at high levels in recent months with various U.S. interlocutors. Its potential implications for not just the bilateral relationship but also the international energy market have been very clearly articulated by the Indian side

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTRY



have been under additional pressure owing to the U.S.-Iran conflict and New Delhi's import of Russian oil hit an 11-month high in April this year. However, the U.S. Treasury paused sanctions for oil shipments that were in transit before March 11, as supplies were hit following the start of the conflict in West Asia on February 28.

"To China and India: You better clean up your

act. Buy your oil and gas somewhere else," said Senator Richard Blumenthal, a Connecticut Democrat, shortly after the Bill was passed.

Countries that would be potential targets for the tariff are the top five "largest importers, by total volume" of Russian-origin crude oil or natural gas in the 12 months preceding the date of enactment of the law, and have knowing-

Over half of oil imports in July were from Russia

NEW DELHI

Russia accounted for more than 51% of India's oil imports in July, an all-time-high, up from just a little less than 50% in the previous month, the latest official data shows. An analysis of Commerce and Industry Ministry data shows India imported 110.4 lakh tonnes of Russia oil in July, the latest month for which data is available. » PAGE 12

ly made new purchases of Russian crude oil on or after 30 days from the date the Bill becomes law.

A country that is among the top five countries "facilitating Russian oil sanctions evasion" would also be eligible for the tariffs of up to 100%.

Countries that have taken significant steps to reduce their Russian natural gas imports or whose gas imports were less than 15%

of Russia's total gas export, would be exempt from the sanctions.

A House amendment proposed by Democrat Steny Hoyer that sought to name the top 10 importers – China, India, Türkiye, Azerbaijan, Hungary, Slovakia, the UAE and the Kyrgyz Republic – had not passed into the final version considered on Wednesday.

Sweeping powers

The Bill, named after Senator Lindsey Graham, a prominent voice supporter of Ukraine, who died suddenly on July 11 this year, had passed the Senate 86-11 on August 7.

Several prominent Democrats, like Elizabeth Warren and those caucusing with Democrats like Bernie Sanders, as well as some Republicans, such as Rand Paul, had opposed the Bill, concerned over the sweeping powers it would give the President or the cost it would impose, via tariffs, on Americans.

Several lawmakers have been concerned that the ability of Mr. Trump to impose tariffs on U.S. allies – such as Canada and the European Union in its entirety – would be bolstered by the Act.

The Ranking Member (i.e., from the chamber's minority or Democratic party) of the House Foreign Affairs Committee (HFAC), Gregory Meeks, criticised the Bill. "We cannot grant the President more tariff power that, we know, he will abuse," Mr. Meeks said, adding that it would cost at least \$3000 per American family, assuming Mr. Trump restricted tariffs on the top five importers of Russian oil.

In remarks on Tuesday, Mr. Meeks had emphasised that he supported sanctions on Russia, arguing that the President already had powers to sanction Russia but was not using them.

CHINA, RUSSIA REACT » PAGE 14

Chandrasekaran returns as chairman of Tata Sons; Trusts calls move 'illegal'

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

A major dispute has arisen between Tata Sons Pvt. Ltd.'s Board and its majority owner, Tata Trusts, regarding the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as Tata Sons chairman and the listing of the company as mandated by Reserve Bank of India guidelines. Tata Trusts has termed the appointment "illegal".

On Thursday, at a scheduled board meeting of Tata Sons, the Board requested Mr. Chandrasekaran to reconsider his decision to not seek reappointment and continue for five years and he "acceded to the request". "The Board thereafter resolved by a majority vote to re-appoint him as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years upon the expiry of his current tenure [in February 2027]," Tata Sons said in a statement.

On August 12, Mr. Chandrasekaran had said that he would not seek reappointment since one board member, Noel Tata, did not approve it.

While four board members – Venu Srinivasan, Harish Manwani, Saurabh Agarwal and Anita M. George – approved the reappointment, Mr. Tata, also the chairman of Tata Trusts that holds a 66% stake in the holding company, voted against it.

The Board also resolved to initiate steps to comply with RBI guidelines and decided to seek guidance from the RBI, Tata Trusts and other stakeholders on



On August 12, N. Chandrasekaran had said that he would not seek reappointment since one board member did not approve it. ANI

applicable compliance requirements, it said.

On Saturday, the RBI rejected Tata Sons' application to de-register its Core Investment Company NBFC licence and directed it to immediately comply with listing regulations.

2025 resolution

Tata Sons said the Board had received from Tata Trusts its unanimous resolution, dated July 28, 2025, expressing its appreciation of Mr. Chandrasekaran "for his stewardship of the Group from 2017 onwards".

"In recognition of these efforts, the Tata Trusts resolved that he be re-appointed as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years upon the expiry of his current term. Subsequently, in September 2025, the Board of Tata Sons agreed in principle to re-appoint Mr. Chandrasekaran as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years," it said in a statement.

"Pursuant to applicable provisions of law, the

Board decided to obtain the relevant formal approval in February 2026. But in the absence of unanimity, the resolution was deferred for decision. In subsequent Board meetings in May 2026 and June 2026, this matter was discussed but was not resolved," the company said.

In view of the above, on August 12, Mr. Chandrasekaran, in a letter, had opted not to offer himself for reappointment. On September 3, the Nomination and Remuneration Committee (NRC) of the Board, comprising Mr. Srinivasan, Mr. Manwani and Ms. George, met to discuss the re-appointment.

"After due deliberation and in recognition of his contributions and the larger interests of the Tata Group, the NRC unanimously resolved to request him to reconsider his decision and to recommend him for re-appointment at the next Board meeting," the statement said.

RELATED REPORT ON » PAGE 4

INBRIEF



Jarange calls off fast, gives 3-month ‘ultimatum’ to govt.

Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil ended his 20-day hunger strike on Thursday after discussions with a government delegation and giving the State a three-month ultimatum to meet his demands. “We won’t stop without getting what we want. We will give the government more time and have been fighting for three years, and we will show trust for three more months,” said Mr. Jarange-Patil after speaking to the delegation, including Minister Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, Minister Dadaji Bhuse and MLAs Prasad Lad and Suresh Dhas.

CJP launches ‘Adivasi School Theek Karo’ in Rajasthan

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday announced the launch of its “Adivasi School Theek Karo” campaign in Rajasthan and will visit government schools in tribal-dominated areas to document shortcomings in infrastructure and other facilities. During the campaign, its team will cover tribal areas in Udaipur, Dungarpur, Jhalawar, Banswara, Sirohi and Baran-Anta, among other places, the CJP said in a statement. It said its teams would document the condition of schools, identify shortcomings and take up the issues with the authorities concerned. The CJP said it would also monitor the implementation of announcements by the Rajasthan government for improvement of school infrastructure. PTI

PM releases Annapurna Yojana instalment, says no more ‘cut money’ in Bengal

Around 1.5 crore beneficiaries get ₹3,000 each; Modi says over 50 lakh families will be identified and given *pucca* houses in the State and BJP govt. is taking forward all stalled Central schemes

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Releasing the fourth instalment of Annapurna Yojana to women in West Bengal, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday said the culture of cut money in the State has ended. The PM said that the people of Bengal have been deprived of the benefits of many Central schemes for a long time.

“The BJP is taking forward all the stalled schemes,” he said, adding that more than 50 lakh families will be identified and given *pucca* houses. “We will all build a new Bengal together,” the Prime Minister added.

“The money [for Annapurna Yojana] is directly transferred to the bank accounts of the women without any intermediary. Now there is no cut-money in West Bengal,” Mr. Modi said during a virtual address.

Cut money refers to commission charged by lo-



PM Narendra Modi sharing his message via videoconference on Annapurna Yojana payout, in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

cal politicians to help citizens avail benefits of the government schemes and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leadership, including the PM, had promised to stop corruption if the BJP is elected to power in Bengal.

‘None to be left out’

Mr. Modi said the government believes in “speaking less and working more”. The Prime Minister, on his birthday, also said that no eligible women will be deprived of the benefits of Annapurna Yojana in West

Bengal. Mr. Modi released the fourth instalment of the scheme of ₹3,000 to around 1.5 crore women beneficiaries in the State.

“Within a few days of forming our government in Bengal, work began on the Annapurna Yojana. Today, many women receive financial assistance directly into their bank accounts... Our government aims to ensure that not a single eligible woman is deprived of the benefits of Annapurna Yojana,” he said.

Mr. Modi said that the

Annapurna Yojana is an important effort to strengthen the confidence of Bengal’s women and added that he believes that the women of the State should have both the power to take decisions and the courage to move forward.

Party’s poll promise

The BJP had promised this initiative during the West Bengal Assembly poll campaign. The promise was to counter Trinamool Congress government’s Lakshmir Bhandar scheme where over 2.2 crore were getting ₹1,500 per month.

Assuming power in May 2026, the BJP government started verifying beneficiaries, something the Opposition criticised as a diversion from what the BJP had promised. The Lakshmir Bhandar was a universal scheme, whereas Annapurna Bhandar has an eligibility criterion.

There have been some protests with women claiming they were denied the scheme’s benefits despite being eligible.

Disha’s father sends ₹500-cr. defamation notice to Aaditya

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

Former celebrity manager Disha Salian’s father, Satish Salian, has sent a ₹500-crore defamation notice to Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aaditya Thackeray and former Maharashtra Home Minister Anil Deshmukh over remarks made about him while he is pursuing a fresh probe into his daughter’s death.

The notice seeks ₹500 crore in compensation for what it describes as “false, malicious and defamatory allegations” against Mr. Salian and for “falsely portraying his pursuit of justice as politically motivated, mala fide and actuated by ulterior motives”.

Referring to Mr. Thackeray, the notice stated, “Being yourself specifically named as one of the principal offenders in the FIR complaint, you chose to intervene in the aforesaid proceedings and actively opposed his petition seeking registration of an FIR and an independent investigation.”

Mr. Thackeray on Wednesday denied any connection with Salian or her death. “I have never met or known Disha Salian. Link-



Aaditya Thackeray has denied any connection with Disha Salian or her death. FILE PHOTO

ing my name to this tragic case is a deliberate, evidence-free attempt at character assassination,” he stated in a post on X.

Salian, 28, a former manager of late actor Sushant Singh Rajput, died on June 8, 2020, after allegedly falling from a residential building in Mumbai’s Malad.

Uddhav warns of action

Shiv Sena (UBT) president Uddhav Thackeray on Thursday denied that his family had any connection with the case and warned of legal action if what he described as a campaign of “character assassination” continued.

“Those who want to investigate can keep investigating. But enough of this pointless character assassination, or else we will initiate legal steps,” he said. (With inputs from PTI)

Sanjay Jha facilitating JD(U)’s merger with BJP; can expect outcome soon, says Tejashwi

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Amid the controversy over implementing the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in Bihar and the possibility of re-naming the ruling Janata Dal (United) to Janata Dal (Nitin), Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav on Thursday reiterated that JD(U) will now “merge” with the BJP, and that JD(U)’s national working president has been facilitating this “merger”.

“JD(U)’s inability to come out with a clear stand on the UCC is proof of what holds for the party in the coming days. I’ve been saying again and again that JD (U) is a B-team of BJP and now I’m saying that the party will merge with the BJP in the coming days,” said the Leader of the Opposition while speaking to mediapersons in Patna.



RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav said JD(U)’s inability to come out with a clear stand on UCC is proof of what holds for the party. FILE PHOTO

“Earlier, we had said that Nitish Kumar will not be allowed to remain as the Chief Minister of the State and see what happened,” he pointed out.

Meanwhile, JD(U) has called a meeting of all party leaders in Patna on Friday after Union Home Minister Amit Shah said that “UCC will be implemented in all 21-BJP ruled States by 2029”.

Though political experts said the party would discuss these issues in the

meeting, JD(U) leaders said it would be the party’s “orientation and training programmes for lawmakers”. Experts from outside the State have been invited, said the party’s national working president, Sanjay Kumar Jha.

Earlier, JD(U) leaders Shrawan Kumar and Deputy CM Vijay Kumar Chaudhary had said that the party would study the provisions of the UCC first and Mr. Jha “would hold talks with Mr. Shah over this”.

Why build a new Secretariat at a time of financial crisis: EPS

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Thursday opposed the TVK-led government’s move to construct a new Secretariat-Assembly complex at Pattinapakkam in Chennai.

Addressing the media in Madurai, he pointed to the “huge borrowings” made by the TVK government since it came to power in May, adding, “In just the first four months, the new government has borrowed ₹40,000 crore. If this is the financial position of the State, why is the TVK government planning to construct a new Secretariat building now?”

Mr. Palaniswami said that after addressing the State’s financial crisis, the government should choose a different site for the new Secretariat, one that would



AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami addressing the media in Madurai on Thursday.

not adversely affect the people. “The government should reconsider the Pattinapakkam site, where the fishing community lives. The area witnesses a lot of traffic jams,” he said.

While Energy Resources Minister C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar had been “denying” the fact that there were frequent power cuts in the State, an additional 2,000 MW was being procured from the open market to mitigate the power shortage, he said.

West Bengal police arrest Maoist central committee member Asim Mandal

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

A team of the Special Task Force of the West Bengal Police on Thursday arrested top Maoist central committee member Asim Mandal alias Akash.

Akash, who joined the Maoist insurgency in 1980s, had been serving as the Central Committee Member and also the Secretary of Communist Party of India (Maoist) West Bengal State Committee-I.

A total of ₹2.20 crore bounty was declared on his name – ₹1 crore by the Jharkhand government and ₹1.20 crore by Odisha.

Highlighting that West Bengal maintained zero tolerance policy towards any extremist ideology, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said the accused was arrested from Purba Medinipur’s Patashpur.



Asim Mandal alias Akash

“Evading law enforcement for more than 15 years across inter-State forest belts, his apprehension on the basis of sharp technical intelligence demonstrates the exceptional operational competence of our police force. I want to make it categorically clear that the West Bengal government will not tolerate any attempt to revive or expand the network of ‘Red Terror’ within our State borders,” he said on X.

According to the officials, Akash took charge of

the Bengal unit of CPI (Maoist) in 2011 after the death of senior commander Kishenji alias Mallojula Koteswara Rao. Hailing from Paschim Medinipur, Akash had been active in Jharkhand in the last few years as the insurgency movement declined in West Bengal after Kishenji’s death.

“We have been tracking his movement for a long time. Few days ago, he entered West Bengal’s Patashpur for shelter. Based on our internal inputs, we have arrested him on Thursday,” said Kolkata Police Commissioner Ajay Nanda. Police are interrogating him to uncover operational details regarding active cadre networks.

The Commissioner said the government might consider providing necessary support for his return to the ‘mainstream’.

Arunachal CM denies arm-twisting people to push mega dam on Siang

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu has trashed perceptions that the government was arm-twisting people to push a mega dam project on the Siang river, which flows as the Yarlung Tsangpo in Tibet upstream.

The government remained open to discussions with villagers and organisations opposed to the proposed Siang Upper Multipurpose Project, Mr. Khandu said. The project’s capacity is expected to range between 11,000 megawatts (MW) and 12,500 MW.

The Chief Minister’s assertion that “there is nothing forceful” came days af-



Pema Khandu said that the government’s doors are open for people who harboured concerns about the project. X/@PEMAKHANDUBJP

ter the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) registered a case against lawyer and anti-dam activist Bhanu Tatak for allegedly receiving foreign funds in violation of the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act or FCRA.

“The discussions on the proposed project and its pre-feasibility report have

been ongoing for two years. Many villagers have come forward and signed Memoranda of Understanding in favour of the project,” Mr. Khandu said.

‘Open for discussion’

The government’s doors were open for people who harboured concerns about the Siang Upper Multipur-

pose Project. “Any organisation, individual, or group with any doubt regarding the pre-feasibility report can come and discuss with the government,” he said.

India has justified pursuing the project as a countermeasure against the 60,000 MW Medog hydropower station that China is building on the Yarlung Tsangpo.

Although the Arunachal Pradesh government has garnered support from several villages for the Siang Upper Multipurpose Project, many people across four districts – East Siang, Siang, Upper Siang, and West Siang – are opposing the project over possible displacement, environmental impact, and seismic risks.

Gurugram hit-and-run accused chased woman biker for 2 km after party: SIT

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

The main accused in the Gurugram hit-and-run case, Kalyan Bainsla, was returning from a party with his three friends when he chased a woman biker for 2 kms on the Golf Course Road before hitting her motorcycle, the Special Investigation Team (SIT) sources said on Thursday.

According to the SIT, Mr. Kalyan, who was driving the car and his three friends had been at Empire Club Bar and Lounge in Sector 25 on the intervening night of September 13 and 14, the sources said.

His friend, Mr. Lavnish, was seated in the passenger seat at the time of the



Kalyan Bainsla (left) and Lavnish were nabbed from Rajasthan on September 15. PTI, ANI

incident. The first interaction between the occupants of the car and the biker, Shivani Chauhan took place near Sector 53 Metro station, the sources said.

Following a brief altercation, Mr. Lavnish instigated Mr. Kalyan to chase the biker, following which they pursued her for



around 2 kms before hitting her two-wheeler. The collision threw her off the motorcycle and she suffered injuries to her knees.

Mr. Kalyan and Mr. Lavnish were nabbed from Rajasthan on September 15 and a case was registered under relevant sections.

The sequence of events remains the central focus

of the investigation. While Ms. Shivani has alleged that the occupants of the car were intoxicated and deliberately chased and hit her, Mr. Kalyan, has said that the collision was an accident.

Notices served

The five-member SIT investigating the case has also served notices to the two other occupants and their statements will be recorded to determine if their arrests are required. Additionally, investigators have sought the club’s CCTV footage, and the blood and urine samples of the accused have been sent for forensic examination.

Meanwhile, Ms. Shivani demanded action against everyone involved.

‘CM’s U.K. trip draws bids of ₹15,300-cr. for investment’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, who visited the U.K. to meet industrialists and attract investments to the State, returned to Chennai on Thursday. A press release said investment commitments worth ₹15,300 crore had been received during the visit, which would generate 10,000 direct and indirect jobs.

Mr. Vijay met Indian High Commissioner Kumaran Periyasamy and held discussions on joint ventures between India and the U.K. under the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA).

As Mr. Vijay had already announced in the Assembly that his government intended to establish a world-class Sports City, he visited the Silverstone Motor Racing Circuit, and held discussions on modern car-racing technology and security arrangements.

The government said a memorandum of understanding (MoU) had been signed with Samvardhana Motherson International Ltd. and its partners in Europe and Britain for an investment of ₹11,000 crore.

Two MoUs were also signed for establishing global capability centres (GCCs).

The State government also signed an MoU with the U.K.-based Wilson Power Solutions for manufacturing transformers at an investment of ₹300 crore in Tiruvallur.

National integration must involve equal rights for citizens: V-P

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

National integration must go beyond the geographical unification of territories and translate into equal rights, dignity and opportunities for citizens, Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan said on Thursday.

Addressing the Hyderabad Liberation Day celebrations organised by the Union Ministry of Culture, in Hyderabad, Mr. Radhakrishnan, who was the chief guest, said September 17, 1948, marked the culmination of a decisive chapter in the history of independent India with the integration of the erstwhile Hyderabad State into the Indian Union.

“Political integration can bring territories together; constitutional democracy brings citizens together,” he said, stressing that national unity could not be sustained by geography alone and had to be reinforced through equal rights, equal dignity and equal opportunity.

Recalling the contribution of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel towards the integration of the princely States, Mr. Radhakrishnan said the first Home Minister had shouldered an extraordinary responsibility when the country was recovering from Partition and simultaneously consolidating hundreds of princely States into one Union.

Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla called upon people to draw inspiration from the sacrifices of the libera-



C.P. Radhakrishnan

tion heroes and contribute to building a strong, prosperous and developed Telangana.

‘People-centric govt.’ Meanwhile, Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy appealed to the people to cooperate in building a modern Telangana, with the spirit of past struggles. He was speaking after unfurling the Tricolour at the Public Gardens here to celebrate the “Praja Palana Dinotsavam”.

“We are running a people-centric administration upholding the Telangana spirit and prioritising self respect of the people. Telangana is competing not just with neighbouring States but with the entire world,” he said.

Outlining the various initiatives launched by the Congress government since it took over the reins in December 2023, he said the State’s per capita income was ₹4.18 lakh, 91% higher than the national average. The government’s main goal, however, was to ensure that development was reflected not in statistics but in the actual lives of the people.

Navodaya case: SC tells T.N. to change ‘anti-Hindi’ mindset

Court says ‘individual States cannot act like individual countries’, gives govt. 3 months to identify land for Navodaya schools in each district; TVK govt. says choice of language is fundamental right

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday said Tamil Nadu has to change the “mindset” that Hindi cannot be taught on the soil of the State, cautioning that “individual States cannot act like individual countries”. The oral observations from Justice B.V. Nagarathna came in a hearing on the adoption of the Navodaya Vidyalaya Scheme in Tamil Nadu.

The top court gave the State three months to comply with a December 15, 2025, order to identify the requisite land for Navodaya schools in each district. It said the direction would be subject to final orders passed later on. In the interregnum, the State and Central representatives were asked to discuss the policy of establishing Navodaya schools in Tamil Nadu. “Chennai should not



Education is a constant. It does not depend on the whims of any government. Today it is Navodaya, but if the same precedent is taken up in other areas of governance, what will happen to our country?

JUSTICE B.V. NAGARATHNA
Supreme Court

alienate Delhi, and vice versa, too,” Justice Nagarathna, heading a Bench including Justice A.G. Masih, addressed both governments.

The Tamil Nadu government has opposed the scheme as “fundamentally incompatible” with the State’s two-language policy. The previous Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) government, in an affidavit filed in March this year, had said the Navodaya scheme, based on the three-language formula,

deviated from the mandate of the Tamil Nadu Tamil Learning Act, 2006. The affidavit had alleged that the scheme was only a “backdoor” ploy to make Hindi compulsory.

On Thursday, the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) dispensation equally objected to the scheme, saying the choice of language is a fundamental right.

Senior advocate Jaideep Gupta and Tamil Nadu Additional Advocate-General HariPriya Padmanabhan,

for the State, said the scheme cannot be forced upon the State against its own policies and laws.

Mr. Gupta said ‘education’ was a subject in the Concurrent List.

“Navodaya is an optional policy... If the Supreme Court now issues a mandamus to the State to adopt that optional policy of the Centre, then My Lords, what you are doing is upsetting 75 years of decision-making by this court,” Mr. Gupta submitted.

“Change of government changes nothing. Education is a constant. It does not depend on the whims of any government. Today it is Navodaya, but if the same precedent is taken up in other areas of governance, what will happen to our country? You cannot say ‘I will not allow the national industrial policy or the national financial policy,’” Justice Nagarathna said.



E.M. Sudarsana Natchiappan

Cong. leader Sudarsana Natchiappan passes away

B. Kolappan
C. Palanivel Rajan
SIVAGANGA

Senior Congress leader and former Union Minister E.M. Sudarsana Natchiappan passed away at his residence in Sivaganga on Thursday. He was 78, and is survived by his wife, daughter, two sons, and two elder brothers.

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president Manickam Tagore, a nephew of Natchiappan, said his uncle had died in his sleep. “When he did not wake up in the morning, his driver went to his room, only to find that he was no more,” Mr. Tagore told *The Hindu*.

A Congressman since 1969, Natchiappan rose through the ranks from his early days as Singampunari Regional Youth Congress president to become vice-president of the TNCC in 2002. He also served as party whip in Parliament.

Natchiappan, an expert on the Sri Lankan Tamils issue, fishermen’s rights, and the Katchatheevu islet, had addressed the United Nations General Assembly on two occasions.

INBRIEF



Shivakumar unveils Kalyana Karnataka Economy Mission

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Thursday announced the establishment of the Kalyana Karnataka Economy Mission (KKEM) as a Section 8 company (a non-profit organisation registered under the Companies Act) to attract investment and accelerate industrial development in the Kalyana Karnataka region. The Liberation Day is observed on September 17 every year to commemorate the end of the Nizam’s rule, and the region’s integration with the Indian Union in 1948.

Man attacks wife with ‘acidic substance’ in Bengaluru

A 26-year-old woman was attacked with a machete, and a suspected acidic substance was poured on her allegedly by her husband near a private hospital in J.P. Nagar in south Bengaluru on Thursday. The incident occurred when the woman, Madhumita, stepped out of the hospital where she was working. The accused, identified as Venkatesan, allegedly attacked her and fled for some distance before a traffic police intercepted and detained him. The couple, married three years ago, had been living separately for the past year following marital discord, the police said.

A.P. farmer, daughter found dead; 10-year-old son critical

A 44-year-old tenant farmer and his 13-year-old daughter were found dead in Gandrai village of NTR district of Andhra Pradesh on Thursday, the police said. His 10-year-old son, who was found in a critical condition along with them, is undergoing treatment in Hyderabad. The farmer, P. Srinivas, is suspected of having resorted to the extreme step after harming the children, the police said. What drove him to take the extreme step is yet to be ascertained, the police added. (For those in distress, counselling is available at Tele MANAS 14416.)

Ready for service



Rescue brigade: New recruits trained in firefighting, rescue operations, and disaster response pass out from the Kerala Fire and Rescue Services Academy in Thrissur, Kerala. K.K.NAJEEB

Keralam court sends Reporter TV director to judicial custody

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Anto Augustine, managing director of Malayalam news channel Reporter TV, was remanded in judicial custody for 14 days by a Magistrate Court in Wayanad, Keralam, late on Thursday. He was earlier arrested by the excise officials on charges of alleged possession of liquor in excess of the legally permissible limit.

Mr. Augustine was taken into custody around 5 a.m. from the channel’s office at Kalamassery in Ernakulam district. The move followed the recovery of 67 litres of liquor from his an-

He was arrested by excise officials for allegedly possessing liquor in excess of the legal limit

cestral residence in Wayanad, on Wednesday by the special investigation team (SIT). The SIT is probing the alleged financial fraud linked to the failed bid to bring the Argentine national football team and its former captain Lionel Messi to Kochi for an international friendly last year.

The accused has been booked under Sections 55(a), 55(i), and 58 of the Kerala Abkari Act.

Karnataka’s financial aid scheme helped woman to sustain psychiatric care: study

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

A case study highlighting how financial assistance provided under the Karnataka government’s Gruha Lakshmi scheme helped a 40-year-old woman continue treatment for a chronic psychiatric disorder has been published in the *Digital Journal of Clinical Medicine*, brought out by the Elsevier publication for JSS Academy of Higher Education and Research (JSSAHER).

The case study concerns Girija (name changed), who was diagnosed with bipolar disorder and has been undergoing treatment for the past 25 years. A homemaker who has



The Gruha Lakshmi scheme provides ₹2,000 a month to eligible women identified as the heads of households. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

been married for 22 years, she belongs to a nuclear family from a lower socioeconomic background. Her husband works as a daily wage labourer.

Her psychiatric condition worsened amid financial stress in the house-

CMRL director also retracted statement to ED in pay-off case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

S.N. Sasidharan Kartha, managing director of Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL), had also submitted a retraction affidavit to the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in 2024 in connection with the statements recorded in the Exalogic-CMRL pay-off case, it has now emerged.

CMRL’s former chief financial officer P. Suresh Kumar, along with the present chief general manager, had similarly submitted retraction affidavits to the ED in 2024.

Mr. Kartha was interrogated by the ED at his residence on April 17, 2024.

In his statement recorded under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, Mr. Kartha allegedly admitted to transferring funds to vendors and withdrawing cash without genuine expenses. He also admitted to payments made to T. Veena, and her now-defunct firm Exalogic Solutions Pvt. Ltd.

In an email to the CMRL dated May 15, 2024, Mr. Kartha’s brother N. Ajith alleged that ED officials had forcibly recorded his brother’s statements. “I would like to inform you that in this connection, I had submitted a retraction affidavit, on behalf of my brother, to the Director, ED Delhi office,” the mail read.

tance received under Gruha Lakshmi, a State government welfare scheme that provides ₹2,000 a month to eligible women identified as the heads of households.

“Women with severe mental illness face compounded vulnerability due to gender-based economic dependence, limited workforce participation and caregiving responsibilities. In such contexts, social welfare schemes aimed at women may serve as critical enablers of mental health care access,” said the case report.

The abstract of the case report describes mental health disorders as a “major global public health challenge”.

Worry over survey on ‘charge’ for free e-learning modules

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

The National Programme on Technology Enhanced Learning (NPTEL), a Ministry of Education body, surveyed learners regarding a potential charge for its currently free e-learning materials. The agency clarified that the purpose of the exercise was solely to collect feedback from learners.

NPTEL said the survey did not indicate any imminent stoppage of funding. It said this after learners who had received the survey email raised questions on whether the Union government was halting funding in the coming year and if NPTEL was moving towards a self-sustaining model with a potential of hike in fees for conducting its certification exams as well as charging for accessing its free content.

NPTEL is a consortium of seven Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) – Bombay, Delhi, Kanpur, Kharagpur, Madras, Guwahati and Roorkee – along with the Indian Institute of Science (IISc). It offers over 70,000 hours of online lecture videos with close to 600 courses every semester across 22 disciplines

NPTEL clarified that the purpose of the exercise was ‘to collect feedback from learners’

from engineering to humanities, through SWAYAM platform for certification and credit transfer to lakhs of students every year.

‘Self-sustaining model’
In an email sent to its learners, the agency said, “If the government funding is withdrawn and NPTEL is unable to secure funding through other sources, NPTEL may need to transition to a self-sustaining model from 2027.”

In the survey, NPTEL posed two options. Firstly, it has stated that if the government funding is withdrawn, then NPTEL should continue to offer courses by charging nominal additional fee to the learners. Secondly, it has proposed that NPTEL should stop offering courses altogether.

Social media users questioned the NPTEL’s motive behind instituting the survey, voicing worries about the impact on rural and low-income students.

PM pitches India as a global destination for chipmaking

The country’s success in the critical industry would strengthen supply chain of entire world, says Modi; 1 lakh technicians to be trained over five years for employment in factories, adds IT Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi pitched India as a “new and trustworthy location” for electronics manufacturing, urging global chipmakers to consider the country’s potential to relieve electronics from the “weaponisation” of supply chains.

“This is not a sector where you set up a factory and the job is done,” said Mr. Modi, who inaugurated Semicon India 2026. “Wherever semiconductor ecosystems have been built in the world, the entire ecosystem has come together only after decades of hard work. But India, with your cooperation, has worked simultaneously on chip design, manufacturing, equipment manufacturing, the materials ecosystem, testing capability, and has demonstrated success.”

The Prime Minister’s address came days after the India Semiconductor Mission’s (ISM) second phase, which has an outlay of ₹1.27 lakh crore, was notified.

Describing India as the



High potential: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw at SEMICON India in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

“mother of democracy”, he said, “When such a country succeeds in a critical industry, it strengthens the supply chain of the entire world. And today, when supply chains are being weaponised, its importance becomes much greater. We should also look at this development taking place in India from this larger perspective.”

Semicon India 2026 brought together semiconductor and electronics firms from India and other countries. Speaking at the event, IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the govern-

ment plans to train one lakh people who will be a “global pool of talent” and can “straightaway be employed in the factories which are coming up in India”.

Mr. Vaishnaw said the government would target at least 200 start-ups and firms in ISM 2.0’s chip design pillar, almost double of what was done for the first phase.

The Minister added that the government was committed to training more than one lakh technicians over the coming five years for different electronics

manufacturing duties.

Global industry body SEMI’s CEO Ajit Manocha estimated that the semiconductor industry would cross \$1.3 trillion this year, and \$2 trillion by 2030.

Leaders from the semiconductor industry expressed hope in India’s trajectory and its role in their global plans. Applied Materials committed to invest \$5 billion over the coming five years to expand its R&D centre and supply chain.

“Earlier this year, we began commercial production at Sanand,” Micron CEO Sanjay Mehrotra said. “Our current production capacity already exceeds the memory required for India’s entire laptop market ... The India Semiconductor Mission, and now ISM 2.0, gave this industry a foundation it did not have before.”

Infineon CEO Jochen Hanebeck called India a “market of tremendous importance”, praising the “pace of progress across the Indian ecosystem”. Pointing to his firm increasing hiring in India by 28%, he said that there was great potential for India in the sector.

Plea flagging issues in Delhi SIR to get ‘precedence’ in SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday agreed to give “precedence” in hearing to a writ petition raising discrepancies in the conduct of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll in Delhi, including the removal of lakhs of voters from the draft roll for nebulous reasons.

“We will list it on Monday. Such matters will have precedence,” Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said.

The CJI was reacting to an oral mentioning by advocates Prashant Bhushan and Neha Rathi of a petition filed by activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri.

The plea flagged that apart from the more than 47 lakh names that have been removed as per the draft roll, the Election Commission (EC) was preparing notices to 33 lakh people on two grounds: logical discrepancies and mapping.

“Out of 97,53,577 electors who are listed on the draft Delhi SIR roll after the enumeration phase, 33,12,919 electors (33.96%) are being issued notices af-

The petition said the EC has not defined ‘logical discrepancies’ or laid guidelines to categorise them

ter being identified for either having no mapping (13,79,785) or for logical discrepancies (19,33,134). However, the respondents (Election Commission and the Chief Electoral Officer, Delhi) have failed to publish the list of electors to whom notices have been issued along with the specific basis thereof, contrary to the procedure,” the petition said.

The petition said the term ‘logical discrepancies’ has neither been defined by the EC nor has any specific criteria to determine the circumstances in which an elector would fall within that category.

In the West Bengal SIR, ‘logical discrepancies’ could include anything from improbable family age gaps and changing parent names to entries backed by only Aadhaar. ‘Mapping’ meant the exercise of verifying voters’ details with earlier records or their families’ generational voting data.

Do not agree to listing of Tata Sons, says Tata Trusts

Lalendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Tata Trusts on Thursday reiterated its position to preserve the structure of Tata Sons and the Tata Group, which is more than a century old.

In a statement on the decision of the Tata Sons Board to follow an order by the Reserve Bank of India on public listing, Tata Trusts said it has asked Tata Sons to explore options other than listing and save the ‘Tata model’. Tata Trusts said it will continue to engage with Tata Sons and the relevant authorities to support a fair, transparent, and legally compliant process.

“Tata Sons Board had already considered the matter of public listing and reached a unanimous conclusion in March 2024, under the guidance of the late Mr. Ratan Tata, and had resolved that the Company should remain unlisted. In July 2025, the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust, also unanimously passed resolutions that the Company should remain unlisted and the same was duly communicated to Tata Sons for necessary action,” it said.

At the Board meeting on Thursday, Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata said, “Tata Group was conceived as a national service carried on through business and has conducted itself so in this manner for over a century. The structure of its ownership is what has allowed it to remain so and has permitted Tata Sons to act repeatedly in ways that a purely commercial calculus would not have supported.”

‘Unique institution’

“Therefore, what is at stake today is something very fundamental: the nature and character of the Tata Group as a unique institution. What makes the Tata operating structure unique is that it is premised on trust and its majority shareholder is a charity. That charity funds



Noel Tata

hospitals, universities, and research from the dividends it receives. It exists for public purpose and for nation building,” he said.

The statement comes on a day when the Tata Trusts opposed the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as Tata Sons chairman.

The decision taken by N. Chandrasekaran in August to not seek reappointment as Tata Sons chairman after his term ended in February 2027 was “duly accepted and has attained finality”, Tata Trusts said.

Tata Trusts said it remains committed to ensuring an orderly and timely leadership transition in the long-term interests of Tata Sons and the Tata Group. “On 12 August 2026, Mr. Chandrasekaran communicated to the Tata Sons Board, his own decision not to offer himself for reappointment – a decision that was freely taken, clearly expressed and not the outcome of any process of review. It was made public without prior intimation or any deliberations with the shareholders of the company. Once such a decision has been publicly communicated, it has consequences which cannot be afterwards undone, since the Group’s employees, its lenders and counterparties, the market and the majority shareholder have all proceeded on it,” Tata Trusts said.

Tata Trusts said it formally placed on record its acceptance of the decision the following day and advised Tata Sons to initiate the process for setting up a selection committee for appointing a successor, in accordance with the Arti-

cles of Association of Tata Sons.

“The Trusts’ position remains unchanged, as a considered judgement of a majority shareholder. This position was reiterated in today’s board meeting by the Chairman, Tata Trusts. The resolution seeking to reappoint Mr. Chandrasekaran in the Board meeting today, with four Directors voting in favour, and Mr. Noel Tata against, was a legal nullity in view of the provisions of the Articles of Association of Tata Sons,” it said.

At the board meeting, Mr. Tata submitted a legal opinion obtained from Justice D.Y. Chandrachud, former Chief Justice of India, regarding the correctness of the Trusts’ stand.

Liquidity to SP Group

At the Board meeting, Mr. Tata proposed providing liquidity to the SP Group, which holds little more than 18% stake in Tata Sons and had been asking for listing.

The proposal was received from the Shapoorji Pallonji (SP Group) regarding monetisation of a portion of their Tata Sons shareholding held by Sterling Investments Corporation Private Limited (SICPL) and Cyrus Investments Private Limited (CIPL).

The transaction envisages a sale of such number of Tata Sons shares held by SICPL and CIPL as would, at a minimum valuation, yield a gross consideration of ₹25,000 crore.

Mr. Tata suggested that various avenues could be used to raise funds for the purpose, including internal cash flows, sale of listed shares, bringing in an investor into some of the newer businesses, and listing, upon an offer for sale, of some of the businesses. He requested the Board to take the necessary steps for initiating the NCLT process and authorise the operating team of Tata Sons and the Tata Trusts to continue discussions with the SP Group, and the bankers, and report to the Board.

The Hindu Bureau
JAMMU

Two Pakistani Jaish-e-Mohammed terrorists were killed and a suspect was detained in an anti-terror operation in Jammu division’s Udhampur district on Thursday.

The Jammu & Kashmir Police identified the two dead terrorists as Saddam and Mustafa. “An AK assault rifle (with four magazines), M4 carbine (with three magazines), a Glock pistol (with two magazines), and four grenades have been recovered from them,” said the police.

The Army said it launched ‘Operation Sohan’ during the intervening night of September 16 and 17 following “con-



Security officials arrest a suspect for his alleged association with two Jaish-e-Mohammad terrorists in Udhampur on Thursday. ANI

firmed inputs indicating the presence of terrorists in Udhampur”.

“Despite hostile weather, difficult terrain and poor visibility, troops of the Army’s White Knight Corps, J&K Police and CRPF launched a targeted

counter-terrorism operation, resulting in the neutralisation of two terrorists,” said the Army. The bodies of the two terrorists were retrieved later from an area with thick vegetation and hilly terrain.

The arrested suspect is

9/11 architects were not hiding in caves, India tells UN Council

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

In a scathing attack on Pakistan, India has said the “architects” of the 9/11 attacks were not hiding in “caves or badlands” but had long evaded detection, asserting that the same “permissive environment” continues to support terror groups such as Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed.

At a UN Security Council (UNSC) meeting, India’s Permanent Representative Harish Parvathaneni said al-Qaeda leaders Osama bin Laden and Khalid Sheikh Mohammed were eventually found in settled communities rather than remote hideouts.

“The international community supported the global campaign to counter terrorism in the wake of 9/11. Let us not forget, however, that al-Qaeda’s terror ecosystem established its strategic depth beyond Afghanistan through its affiliates,” Mr. Parvathaneni



Harish Parvathaneni

said on Wednesday. Addressing the UNSC meeting on the situation in Afghanistan, Mr. Parvathaneni listed the names of al-Qaeda leaders who had planned and carried out the September 11, 2001, attacks.

“The leaders of al-Qaeda who conceived and directed these 9/11 attacks did not escape justice in the wilderness of some un-governed frontier,” he said.

He said that bin Laden, was “tracked down and killed in a fortified compound within a settled, guarded community under Operation Neptune Spear.”

Mohammed, “the principal architect of the operation, was found sheltering in an ordinary residential house. Ramzi Binalshibh, who coordinated the hijacker cell after being denied a visa to join them, was sheltering in an urban centre,” he said.

He said that “the same permissive environment that sheltered the architects of 9/11 has, in the years since, continued to provide space, support, and impunity to affiliates of al-Qaeda such as Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed and their like, acquiring different identities to escape this Council’s sanctions framework and whose leadership and terror training infrastructure have been shielded from consequence.

“The international community must join hands to address the continuity of such sanctuary to ensure that more such individuals are not thrust upon any country or its citizens...,” he said.

Kuki-Zo group warns of full-fledged agitation if demands are not met

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Kuki-Zo Council (KZC) has threatened to launch a “full-fledged agitation” if the Centre fails to address its administrative, humanitarian, and security concerns by October 10, 2026. The organisation accused the National Investigation Agency (NIA) of selective operations against the community.

The KZC said the Kuki-Zo people were facing severe shortages of food and essential commodities in Kamjong, Kangpokpi, Nonhey, and Tamenglong districts due to an economic blockade imposed by the United Naga Council.

The Council also said expressed concern over “selective and disproportionate” operations by the NIA in Kuki-Zo areas, alleging that innocent civilians were frequently summoned by NIA for questioning without adequate

justification, but “fewer operations appear to be conducted in Naga and Meitei areas”.

The KZC further said the bodies of Kuki-Zo people allegedly killed by Naga armed groups would not be buried until an appropriate and acceptable resolution was reached.

It demanded the re-imposition of President’s Rule in Manipur, pointing out that no Kuki-Zo civilian was killed when it was in force between February 2025 and February 2026.

“The Government of India must... ensure the safety and protection of the Kuki-Zo people, and hold those responsible for atrocities and violence accountable. It must also provide a substantive update on the status and progress of the Kuki-Zo political demand and take steps towards achieving an appropriate and acceptable political resolution,” the KZC said in a statement.

Centre must make stance clear on U.S. law: Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

 Our foreign policy and sovereignty cannot be bartered at the altar of our friendship with the United States. National interests cannot be mortgaged at the altar of event management by a weak-kneed BJP govt.

RANDEEP SURJEWALA
Congress general secretary



The government had repeatedly compromised India's interests in dealing

EC bars rival factions from using Trinamool name and symbol for Assembly bypolls

“The EC has once again proven that it is nothing more than a puppet in the hands of the BJP – a tool to destroy democracy bit by bit..” Congress general secretary K.C. Venugopal said in a post on X. He said “freezing the AITC symbol

SC seeks report on 25 unnatural deaths in Manipur camps

The order also referred to a report highlighting that 640 deaths occurred in relief camps across eight districts while post-mortem examinations were allegedly conducted in only 20 cases. The court sought explanations over this and why only ₹20,000 to ₹30,000 was given as compensation in these cases. It also asked State Legal Services Authority to register FIRs in all cases of unnatural deaths.

Wishes, messages pour in for Modi as the PM celebrates 76th birthday

good governance...,” said Ms. Murmu on X.

The Vice-President said: “Under your steadfast and visionary leadership, Bharat is shining as a bright

Congress president and Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge and his Lok Sabha counterpart, Rahul Gandhi, greeted Mr. Modi

After brief disruption, talks resume over Bangladesh PM's visit to India



The Hindu was informed that Mr. Rahman's personal contacts with Indian officials were renewed at least since February 2024 when he had sent an emissary to India to sense India's mood following the widely criticised election of January 2024 that was boycotted by the BNP under his leadership. The engagement was in line with previous exchanges between BNP and India during the Sheikh Hasina era between 2009 and 2024 when she was in power.

'J&K govt. should step down if Omar finds it powerless'



The BJP has opposed the decision to hold a 10-day Assembly session this autumn in Srinagar from September 21. They had demanded a longer session. "... J&K has many issues to discuss [in the Assembly]," said Mr. Sharma.

Cong. rejects claim that its MPs backed MDR move

‘Diverting attention’

The government was seeking to divert attention from the Opposition to the new charges, Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said. "These are pathetic attempts being made by the Modi Govt to divert attention away from the gigantic backlash generated after the UPI tax decision taken to appease US companies & Donaldbhai," Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said on X.

The Finance Committee had not discussed the UPI proposal, Congress's deputy leader in the Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi said. "The Department of Finance did not have any specific proposal on UPI tax when they met the members of the Finance Committee," Mr. Gogoi added.

Questions had been raised about the need for it, but government representatives had not provided specific or satisfactory answers at the time, the Congress leader said.

Mr. Gogoi reiterated the Congress's demand for withdrawal of the policy, saying it would hurt small merchants, vendors, and entrepreneurs while benefiting major U.S. corporations.

INBRIEF



Centre proposes CCTV surveillance at medical stores

The Union Health Ministry has proposed making CCTV surveillance mandatory at licensed premises selling prescription drugs, as part of proposed amendments to the Drugs Rules, 1945. The draft notification, G.S.R. 791(E), issued on September 8, proposes inserting a new provision in Rule 65 requiring the supply of drugs on the prescription of a registered medical practitioner, other than through wholesale dealing, to take place under a CCTV surveillance system installed and maintained at the licensed premises. The Ministry has invited objections and suggestions from stakeholders for 30 days from the date the Gazette was made available.

SC notice to Centre, State over woman's deportation

The Supreme Court on Thursday issued notice to the Centre and authorities in Maharashtra on a petition filed by a man against the detention and deportation of his mother to Bangladesh. The petition also challenged the legality of the standard operating procedure dated May 2, 2025, titled 'Procedure for Deportation of Illegal Bangladeshi Nationals/Rohingya-regarding', and the Immigration and Foreigners Order, 2025. Appearing before a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, petitioner Sahin Fakir alleged that his mother, Ms. Sahida, was illegally detained and "pushed out" of India into Bangladesh in July without any verification of her nationality.

CBFC calls for action against screening of Umar Khalid film

The Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) on Thursday asked IIT-Hyderabad authorities to take action against the proposed screening of *Prisoner No. 626710* is Present on its campus. It is a documentary on activist Umar Khalid, who has been in judicial custody over the past six years in the "larger conspiracy" case linked to the 2020 Delhi riots. "Public screening of a documentary film that has not yet been certified by the CBFC is a violation of the Cinematograph Act unless a specific exemption has been sought under the Act," the CBFC said in a post on X, tagging a screenshot showing that the documentary was to be screened at the institution's campus on Friday.

HC refuses to interfere with order on fund use by CHRI

The Delhi High Court on Thursday declined to interfere with an interim order permitting civil society organisation Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative (CHRI) to withdraw ₹20 lakh from its reserve fund to meet operational expenses, despite the cancellation of its FCRA registration. A Bench of Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia dismissed the Centre's appeal against the May 19 order of a single judge, observing that cancellation of an organisation's FCRA registration does not mean that it ceases to function. It noted that the effect of cancellation was that the organisation could not receive foreign contributions.

Defer Class 6 language policy roll-out to 2027: SC to Centre

Bench says its suggestion is based on logistics and balance of convenience for both students and families; says govt. could use the time to come up with incentives for children for third language

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday urged the Union government to make the three-language policy mandatory for Class 6 from January 1, 2027, rather than "springing a surprise" on the current batch when there is hardly four months left for the year to end.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant was reacting to the Centre's reluctance to change its position to start the policy with the current batch of Class 6.

Justice Joymalya Bagchi, on the Bench with Justice V. Mohana, said the court's suggestion to delay the policy implementation in Class 6 was made on the basis of logistics and balance of convenience for both students and families.

Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Centre, agreed to take the court's suggestion to the government for reconsideration of its position on the issue.

"We are not standing in the way. We are only saying that instead of springing a



Under the CBSE guidelines, Classes 7 to 9 were exempted, while the present Class 6 batch was to face full implementation. FILE PHOTO



We are only saying that instead of springing a surprise on this batch, start from 1st of January

surprise on this batch of students, start from the first of January... We are not on a point of law, but on a point of comfort. You can start with children who come into January 1, 2027. It is only four months more," Justice Bagchi reasoned.

Chief Justice Kant said the government could use the time to come up with incentives for the children

to embrace the study of a third language in school.

"The only incentive for them would be to go and play rather than learn a language," Justice Bagchi said lightly.

The judge said the policy was envisaged in 2020. "Push it to 2027 so that everyone comes to terms with the scheme," Justice Bagchi said.

Taking up on the CJ's suggestion, Justice Mohana said the new language could be taught in a lively and engaging manner that would naturally pique the interest of the children. Language, Justice Mohana indicated, should be learnt in an organic manner.

PAC pulls up Railways over gaps in amenities despite promises

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) on Thursday expressed concern over persistent deficiencies in passenger amenities and sanitation across railway stations, with a recent Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) audit finding that bio-toilets, projected as a game changer by the Indian Railways, were found deficient or non-functional at 491 of the 512 stations inspected.

The findings were discussed at a PAC meeting, headed by senior Congress leader K.C. Venugopal, which examined the CAG's Report No. 31 of 2026 on passenger amenities and sanitation at stations.

Sources said Mr. Venugopal acknowledged the scale and complexity of managing the Indian Railways, but said that should not hamper basic services for citizens. He noted that



K.C. Venugopal

four PAC reports on the subject have been presented since 2007, highlighting key deficiencies, but the Railways ignored the findings. He added that Ministry of Railways continued to submit action-taken reports, without making any significant improvements on the ground.

Sources said the PAC Chairperson directed the Ministry to review the committee's observations, made since its 2007 report, and submit a response within a month detailing measures to address the deficiencies.

"The meeting was one of the most important subjects concerning common passengers in this country. Basic amenities provided to passengers have serious discrepancies, including drinking water, seating arrangements, fans, and roofing on platforms... The audit has pointed out serious lapses on the part of the Railways, which we are examining... After one month, we will call another meeting with Railway officials and we will discuss this" Mr. Venugopal said after the meeting.

The latest audit noted that while the Ministry had informed the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Railways in 2020-21 that it had introduced bio-toilets, water-vending machines and Wi-Fi facilities, several shortcomings remained. Audit teams found deficiencies in water-vending machines at 29 of 77 stations, and Wi-Fi facilities at 65 of 380 stations.

NEET-SS qualifying percentile will be reduced to 30: govt.

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Centre on Thursday agreed to reduce the qualifying percentile for National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test-Super Speciality (NEET-SS) seats from the existing 50 percentile to 30 percentile, even as it agreed to return 40 vacant in-service seats pertaining to Tamil Nadu to the State.

"The matter has since been reconsidered in consultation with the concerned stakeholders. In order to ensure that the available super speciality seats do not remain vacant and that the available training capacity is optimally utilised, it has been decided that the qualifying percentile for NEET-SS may be reduced from the existing 50th percentile to 30th percentile for the purpose of the proposed Special Stray Vacancy Round," a Union government note filed before a Bench headed by Justice P.S. Narasimha said.

Consequently, candidates securing the 30th percentile and above in NEET-SS would become eligible to participate in the special stray vacancy round for NEET-SS seats.

The State was represented by senior advocate A.M. Singhvi, Tamil Nadu Additional Advocate-General Prashanto Chandra Sen and advocate Rupali Samuel. The petitioner, Tamil Nadu Medical Officers Association, was represented by senior advocate P. Wilson, who sought a zero cut-off percentile reduction, as done in the past two years.

The Centre's note said 1,857 super speciality seats were presently lying vacant pursuant to the completion of second round of NEET-SS counselling.

Further, the Centre said its decision to revert the 40 vacant in-service seats to Tamil Nadu was taken in compliance with Supreme Court orders.

"The 40 vacant in-service seats pertaining to Tamil Nadu would be reverted to the State government for the limited purpose of enabling the State to conduct and complete its own stray vacancy round for a period of one week," the Centre submitted.

The court also gave Tamil Nadu leeway to allow NEET-SS candidates upgradation during the one-week special stray vacancy round.

Stem cell therapy for autism only in approved clinical trials: Centre

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Union Health Ministry has asked States and Union Territories to ensure that stem cell therapy is offered as standard clinical care only for disease conditions and indications approved by the Ministry, with its use for Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD) restricted to duly approved clinical trials.

In an advisory issued on September 16, the Ministry reiterated the existing regulatory framework governing stem cell research and therapy. The advisory was issued to States and Union Territories that have adopted the Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010, following a January 30, 2026, judgment of the Supreme Court in *Yash Charitable Trust & Ors. v. Union of India & Ors.*

For ASD, the Ministry said therapeutic use of any



ICMR review said that available evidence does not support stem cell therapy for ASD.

type of stem cell must remain confined to duly approved clinical trials in accordance with the National Guidelines for Stem Cell Research, 2017, issued by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and the Department of Biotechnology.

Stem cell interventions that have not been approved for routine clinical use, including those offered for autism, and

should not be provided as routine, standard or commercial clinical services, the advisory said.

No supporting evidence

The move comes against the backdrop of the continuing use of stem-cell interventions for autism despite the lack of established evidence supporting them as a standard treatment. An ICMR review has said that available evidence does not support stem cell therapy over behavioural and supportive therapies for ASD and recommended that such therapy be restricted to approved clinical trials.

The Ministry has asked States and Union Territories to disseminate the Supreme Court's directions to State and district regulatory authorities as well as government and private clinical establishments involved in stem cell research, treatment, promotion or administration.

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

TH CROSSWORD+ 14901 (set by Arden)

Across

- 1 Fancy cloth as a focus to show a bit of sophistication (1,5,2,5)
- 10 Big land owner is fat, clutching his heart (5)
- 11 Dead simple to pack an Indian carpet (9)
- 12 Agree, no one returned the instrument (9)
- 13 The dictator's internal rule (5)

- 14 Always there is a tiny mistake by the setter (7)
- 16 I've a new design to entwine (7)
- 18 Two drinks socially acceptable at the mansion (7)
- 20 The language of money in South America (7)
- 22 Music starts after main band arrives (5)
- 24 After change of hands, augmentation becomes bleak (9)
- 26 Keen to expose plan for ancient building (9)
- 27 Suffer from strike — part of Mumbai spared (5)
- 28 Coal shortage — I go all over the place for an excavator (13)

Down

- 2 It's almost two — impatient and worried (7)
- 3 Sabotage — result of a French and the German bomb (9)
- 4 Agatha Christie novel avoiding gate crash in the country (5)
- 5 Cast over relative showing off (9)
- 6 Interest seen among legends for a river (5)
- 7 Am I part of retrenched workers? Showing staying power (7)
- 8 Permits for beer — the entire lot has to go (9,4)
- 9 Shoot and catch on (3,3,7)
- 15 Clarify on cryptic clue, I see (9)
- 17 Evading glide overboard (9)
- 19 Perhaps normal to accept one finally as a benefactor (7)
- 21 Brief copies — recoup odd bits inside (7)
- 23 Followers of Amman hungry, not fed (5)
- 25 Stagger carrying cold fish basket (5)

SUDOKU

	2	1	8	5				
6		8		3				5
		5	6					
5					9	8		
8	6						7	2
		3	7					9
					3	6		
1				9		3		8
				8	7	4	9	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

G	E	R	G	A	T	I	G	S
H	E	A	T	H	E	N	I	Z
A	P	E	T	N	A	M	I	L
D	E	T	E	N	T	E	V	A
I	O	X	E	E	R	N		
G	A	R	B	I	N	E	E	R
A								
A	R	M	E	N	T	A	R	E
S	T	A	L	L	R	A	C	O
S	A	C	U	M	B	E	R	E
S	G	U	M	B	E	R	E	
S	I	M	P	A	N	E	L	
I	M	P	A	N	E	L		
N	A	G	E	N	O	Y	H	

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

1	2	5	9	8	3	4	6	7
8	4	9	5	6	7	2	3	1
7	6	3	2	4	1	8	5	9
4	5	7	8	2	9	3	1	6
2	9	1	3	7	6	5	4	8
6	3	8	4	1	5	7	9	2
9	7	4	1	5	8	6	2	3
5	1	6	7	3	2	9	8	4
3	8	2	6	9	4	1	7	5

FAITH

Kallazhagar and Ramanuja

Lord Kallazhagar and Acharya Ramanuja cannot be compared by asking who is greater, because both are closely aligned in role and purpose. Tirukudanthai Dr. Venkatesh highlighted similarities between Kallazhagar and Ramanuja in a discourse. First, the beauty and charm (divine beauty): Kallazhagar is known as Azhagar because of his charming divine appearance. Ramanuja is known for his immense spiritual charm and appealing grace, which attract devotees' hearts.

Second, Ilaya Azhwar (young saint/brother) and Kallazhagar are associated with the qualities of Lakshmana (Lord Rama's younger brother), expressing divine humility and closeness. Ramanuja, born as Ilaya Alzhwar, is considered an incarnation of Lakshmana. Both Kallazhagar and Ramanuja are connected to Srivilliputhur and Andal. Andal honoured Kallazhagar in Her divine hymns Nachiyar Tirumozhi and Tiruppavai. Ramanuja fulfilled Andal's vow to offer a hundred pots of *Akkaravadisal* (sweet rice pudding) to Kallazhagar, earning him the title Koil Annan, Andal's elder brother.

Kallazhagar and Ramanuja both show mercy and accessibility to common people. Kallazhagar reaches out to ordinary devotees and steps out of his grand temple during the Chithirai festival. Ramanuja shared the sacred mantra (Tirumantra) openly from the temple tower of Tirukoshtiyur to ensure salvation for all people.

Kallazhagar is the ultimate grantor of liberation (moksha) through His direct divine grace. Ramanuja serves as the ultimate Acharya (guru), who holds the Lord's feet and guides devotees safely to moksha.

HEALTH

Why patient safety needs more than hospital checklists

Patient safety begins even before treatment: it encompasses the right diagnosis, accurate, timely care, safe hospital environments, protected data and an understanding from all stakeholders to put the patient first, say doctors; the WHO's theme for World Patient Safety Day 2026 is 'safe care for non-communicable diseases'

Siddharth Kumar Singh

A patient enters an operating theatre for a procedure on the right knee. The limb is marked, the scans are available and the surgical team has checked the records. Just before the operation begins, the team stops. A nurse reads out the patient's identity, the procedure planned, the side of the body to be operated on and the type of anaesthesia. The surgeon, anaesthetist and other members of the team confirm the details. This brief pause, known as 'timeout', may take only a few minutes. But it is one of several layers of checks designed to prevent a potentially devastating mistake.

This exercise was an example of what Syed Mohammed Ghouse, consultant robotic and transplant surgeon, Asian Institute of Nephrology and Urology, described as the 'Swiss cheese mechanism', in which several layers of checks are put in place so that if one safety barrier fails, another can detect the error before it reaches the patient.

The need for such multiple safeguards was at the heart of World Patient Safety Day, observed on September 17. The World Health Organization's theme for 2026 was 'Safe care for non-communicable diseases'.

Doctors say patient safety has to be viewed much more broadly than preventing an obvious surgical or medication error. Ranga Reddy Burri, president, Infection Control Academy of India, said the understanding of patient safety has now expanded considerably: the responsibility cannot rest only with doctors and nurses. Policymakers, accreditation agencies, patients, caregivers, families, communities and even housekeeping staff have roles to play. "A hospital just having an accreditation doesn't actually guarantee the kind of safety that is required," Dr. Burri said, stressing the need to train all stakeholders involved in a patient's journey.

Patient safety begins even before treatment starts, noted Dr. Burri. The availability of sophisticated diagnostic equipment has not necessarily solved the problem of ensuring an accurate diagnosis. "The diagnosis quality has actually gone down over a period of time," he said. He attributed part of the problem to doctors moving away from basic clinical examination, including auscultation, percussion, palpation and physical examination. He described the emerging situation as 'no touch' healthcare, where doctors can sometimes begin looking at a computer even before adequately engaging with the patient.

Neurologist Sudhir Kumar of Apollo



Safety first: Hospital staff conducted a mock drill on mass casualty management earlier this year at the Government General Hospital in Ongole. Experts say all stakeholders should have training in patient safety. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

Hospitals, Hyderabad, also pointed to the importance of ensuring quality of medical education as the number of medical colleges and seats increases. "If we don't ensure quality services, then it will worsen the patient's safety because diagnosis may be missed; treatment may not be perfect," he said.

Medication problems

Medication safety remains another major area of concern. Dr. Kumar said spurious and fake medicines continue to pose a patient-safety risk despite the existence of drug inspectors and regulatory checks.

Dr. Ghouse pointed to another problem of look-alike and sound-alike medicines. With a large number of pharmaceutical companies and medicines available, drugs with similar names can create opportunities for errors, particularly when medicines are handled by someone who is distracted or not sufficiently alert.

He said hospitals use measures such as separate labelling and storing look-alike and sound-alike medicines away from each other, along with other quality-control measures.

Technology has reduced some types of prescription errors, but doctors say it has not eliminated them. Dr. Ghouse said typed and printed prescriptions are still not universal, especially at small clinics. Dr. Kumar said prescription errors can also occur when different doctors prescribe medicines under different

brand names or when medicines from the same group are inadvertently duplicated. "For example, a patient may end up taking the same medicine twice because different brand names make it difficult to recognise that the drugs are essentially the same."

Within hospitals

Some patient-safety risks are less dramatic but can still have serious consequences, particularly among older patients. Dr. Burri said falls in hospitals, including falls while patients are going to the bathroom or getting out of bed, can result in major injuries. "Hospitals need to ensure that their physical environments are designed to prevent slipping and other hazards."

Patient safety also extends beyond just their wards or rooms. Dr. Kumar pointed to hospital fires, electrical problems and other infrastructure-related hazards as areas that require greater attention. He said while the number of hospitals was increasing, some facilities are decades old, raising questions about who regularly audits their wiring and electrical connections.

For Dr. Burri, infection prevention and antimicrobial resistance (AMR) remain central to the patient-safety conversation. Unnecessary antibiotic administration, delayed diagnosis, unhygienic environments and non-adherence to infection-prevention and control guidelines can all contribute to the

problem, he said.

These risks can become particularly important for patients with chronic diseases, who may require repeated interactions with healthcare facilities. Dr. Burri said patients with conditions such as chronic kidney disease, lung diseases and cancer may have vulnerabilities that make infection prevention an important component of safe care. "Healthcare workers and administrators therefore have a central role in ensuring that infection-control practices are followed," he added.

Data and AI

As healthcare becomes increasingly digital, patient safety is also becoming connected to data privacy. Dr. Kumar said medical information is private, but increasing digitisation has created new risks around cybersecurity and access to medical records.

Artificial intelligence is increasingly entering healthcare, but Dr. Kumar said it should remain a tool rather than become a substitute for clinical reasoning.

For all the technology, protocols and checklists being introduced in hospitals, the doctors point to one element that cannot be removed from the equation, the patient. Dr. Burri said patients, families, caregivers and communities must understand their own role in ensuring safety.

(siddharth.kumar@thehindu.co.in)

THE GIST

Doctors say patient safety has to be viewed much more broadly than preventing an obvious surgical or medication error. Policymakers, accreditation agencies, patients, caregivers, families, communities and even housekeeping staff have roles to play in patient safety

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HUMERUS



Melanoma in India: messaging about skin cancer needs to change, to catch it early

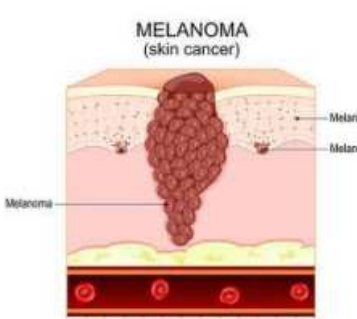
Jyoti Bajpai

Thousands of patients in India are diagnosed with melanoma, a type of skin cancer, each year.

While melanoma is far less common here than in Western populations, it is far from rare and the way it presents in our patient population makes it uniquely difficult to detect early. Too many patients come to us when the disease is already advanced, precisely at a time when treatment options have never been more powerful or more personalised. This contrast between available therapies and the stage at which patients are diagnosed defines one of the most pressing challenges in melanoma care in India today.

The warning signs most people associate with skin cancer come from research developed for fairer-skinned populations, where melanoma tends to appear on sun-exposed areas as an irregular or darkening mole. That picture does not reflect what clinicians see in India.

Melanoma here, most commonly presents on the soles of the feet or beneath the nails, sites that are rarely examined and even more rarely associated with cancer. This condition is called



Spreading awareness: Thousands of patients in India are diagnosed with melanoma, a type of skin cancer, each year. GETTY IMAGES

acral lentiginous melanoma, a subtype that accounts for 35 to 60% of cases in dark-skinned individuals. Such lesions are frequently mistaken for bruises, fungal infections, or diabetic ulcers, and by the time a biopsy is taken, the disease has often progressed.

Mucosal melanomas, a rare type of cancer that starts in the mucous membranes, are highly aggressive with a very low chance of recovery and produce few early warning signs. Most are diagnosed only after spread has occurred.

Any pigmented lesion that changes or persists, wherever it appears on the body, deserves investigation rather than reassurance.

When I began my oncology career, managing advanced melanoma meant offering patients limited and rarely durable options. That has fortunately changed significantly.

The foundational shift came from James Allison and Tasuku Honjo, whose discoveries on CTLA-4 and PD-1 earned them the 2018 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine. Their research established the principle of immune-checkpoint blockade: rather than attacking a tumour directly, we can sometimes release the biological brakes that stop the patient's own immune system from doing so. The results can be extraordinary.

Precision medicine has reshaped the approach in parallel. Some melanomas carry specific mutations, particularly in the BRAF pathway, that can be directly targeted with molecularly designed therapies. This is where next-generation sequencing, or NGS, becomes critical. In simple terms, it reads the genetic blueprint of a patient's tumour and identifies the alterations that should guide treatment, turning what was once a single clinical decision into a detailed, individualised process.

The melanoma story is not over; it is only becoming more

exciting. TIL therapy takes tumour-infiltrating lymphocytes, expands them in the laboratory, and reinfuses them in far greater numbers, a step toward truly personalised cellular treatment. In August 2026, intismeran, a personalised mRNA vaccine built from the patient's own tumour sequence, was combined with pembrolizumab in high-risk melanoma patients after surgery. The results were striking: a significant reduction in recurrence compared with pembrolizumab alone, making it the first positive late-stage trial of a personalised mRNA cancer vaccine, though survival data remain pending.

What still needs to change

All of these advances deliver their best results when treatment begins early. The more sophisticated our therapies become, the more clearly we see that they work best before the disease has spread. In India, awareness and referral gaps continue to push diagnosis toward advanced stages.

(Prof. Jyoti Bajpai is director – medical precision immuno-oncology, Apollo Hospitals, Mumbai & Western Zone drjyoti_ba@apollohospitals.com)



Complex priorities

A fear of political fallout has led to an overly complex MDR structure on UPI

The Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) charges announced for UPI transactions show how political considerations can dilute economic benefits. In a quest to preempt political attacks, the rate structure announced by the National Payments Corporation of India has been made overly complex. From October 15, the new rates will apply only to UPI payments of ₹2,000 or more made at merchants. As such, the charge is limited to only about 2.5% of all UPI transactions, which is a welcome limitation. Yet, within this, the rules have created different gradations. UPI payments made at small merchants earning less than ₹1 lakh a month are exempt. Those made to merchants operating in certain essential sectors will attract a flat MDR charge instead of the 0.4% applicable on other sectors. Capital market payments above ₹2,000 will attract a different MDR. These are clearly designed keeping political backlash in mind. However, they raise some important doubts among merchants, and could potentially slow the adoption of UPI in India. For example, the rules are not clear on what happens to a small merchant who crosses the ₹1 lakh a month turnover threshold, which is a low limit at today's prices. Who is monitoring their incomes? This will either increase the compliance burden on small merchants, or involve a new mechanism for real-time transaction-checking that banks will have to develop. In the short run, it will likely result in small merchants simply refusing to accept UPI until greater clarity emerges.

The government has also instructed banks to make sure that merchants do not pass on this charge to customers. But it has not specified how banks are expected to check whether merchants tweak their prices to absorb this additional charge. A back-of-the-envelope calculation based on past trends suggests that the MDR will yield an upper limit of ₹2,400 crore of monthly revenue for the payments ecosystem. The sector-wise flat rates and reduced rates will likely result in a lower amount. The government has denied any U.S. pressure to bring these rates to favour American credit card companies. Yet, the data suggest that the benefit will largely accrue to private banks and U.S.-owned UPI apps. There is still an argument to be made for the Reserve Bank of India to foot this bill from the vast surpluses it generates every year. Maintaining vital payment infrastructure is surely a good use of these funds. However, if the government persists in implementing this charge, it should certainly simplify the structure. There is still time before its rollout. The Goods and Services Tax experience shows that rate complexity hits small businesses the hardest.

New fault lines

Manipur's new Kuki-Zo-Naga conflict needs firm, even-handed State action

In the three years since the conflagration of May 2023 hardened into a fault line between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities, Manipur has traversed a slow path towards peace between them. After nearly a year of President's Rule gave way in February 2026 to a Bharatiya Janata Party-led government under a new Chief Minister, Yumnam Khemchand Singh, attempts to engineer a thaw gathered pace with the everyday violence between the communities abating. Yet, many of those displaced in 2023 remain in relief camps; an RTI reply puts those dead in these camps at over 700, many due to the lack of access to basic health care and adequate nutrition. Even so, there have been tentative and encouraging openings towards rebuilding normalcy. On September 2, two Kuki-Zo MLAs attended the Assembly session – the first time since legislators from the community began boycotting it following the attacks in Imphal at the start of the ethnic conflict. In doing so they defied a directive from the Kuki-Zo civil society organisation, the Kuki Inpi Manipur, to continue the boycott until there was a concession on the demand for a separate administration. The two MLAs seem to acknowledge that it is time to reopen the political space even if differences persist, and for this, their presence in the Assembly must be welcomed.

Yet, these moves have coincided with a new ethnic fault line in Manipur. Since February, violence between the Naga and Kuki-Zo communities – which began as localised disputes – has spread across the hill districts. Till July, at least 15 Kuki-Zo people, 11 Nagas, three security personnel and a truck driver were killed; more have died in the last two months. Houses in Naga and Kuki-Zo villages have been burnt down and the newly displaced have moved into camps. Blockades imposed by partisans of the communities against the other have held up essentials and medicines, with the smaller Kuki-Zo community the worse affected. Health centres in the hills have been left dysfunctional. This echoes the Naga-Kuki violence of the 1990s, now revived by armed groups claiming to act on behalf of their respective communities and resurrecting arguments over who controls the hills and whose customary laws prevail there. With its tenure ending soon and Assembly elections due next year, the State government must move quickly to contain this outbreak of hostilities. It must work with civil society to lower the rhetoric – reportage from the ground suggests a weariness with the violence across communities – while acting against the armed groups with the help of the security forces. Those imposing blockades must be deterred by the force of law. Criminal law must apply equally across communities in the hills, and the safety and welfare of civilians must be guaranteed irrespective of ethnicity.

The political dominance of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which appeared almost unassailable after 2014, is beginning to show cracks. The 2024 general election was an important setback: the party lost its parliamentary majority and had to depend on its allies to form the government. Since then, disillusionment has acquired greater political salience through youth protests, rising prices, unemployment and failures of governance, particularly irregularities in the education and examination systems. To these can be added the defeat of the Constitutional Amendment Bill on delimitation and women's reservation in April, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests that led to the resignation of the then Union Education Minister and the complete washout of the monsoon session of Parliament, as both the Prime Minister and Home Minister stayed away. Questions over accountability for the excessive police action against student protesters on July 20, compounded by the absence of the two leaders from Parliament, reinforced the impression of a government unwilling to answer for its actions.

But these setbacks do not by themselves amount to an erosion of hegemony. The BJP remains a formidable political force, retaining a substantial electoral base and considerable ideological appeal. What is now at issue is whether the forces that produced the BJP's dominance are beginning to encounter limits. Uttar Pradesh is where this can be most clearly tested.

The citadel of the party's power, 2024 result U.P. is not merely India's most populous State; it is the citadel of BJP power, central to the party's rise to national prominence. In the 2014 general election, the BJP won 71 of the State's 80 seats, establishing it as a crucial pillar of its national power. In the 2019 general election, it won 62 seats on its own despite the formidable alliance of the Samajwadi Party (SP) and the Bahujan Samaj Party. The State's electoral weight was thus instrumental to its successive parliamentary majorities at the Centre. U.P. is still the crucible of the BJP's majoritarian politics and its Hindu-Muslim mobilisation. A weakening of the BJP here would therefore have implications far beyond the State.

The 2024 general election strongly indicates that the BJP had lost ground in U.P. Its tally fell from 62 seats in 2019 to 33, while the SP won 37 and the Congress six. The sharpest erosion occurred in Awadh, once the heartland of the Ayodhya temple movement. In 2022, the BJP won 101 of Awadh's 154 Assembly seats. In 2024, it was



Zoya Hasan

Professor Emerita, Centre for Political Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University

The State's changing electoral landscape, marked by the BJP losing ground in 2024, raises questions about how long the party's political dominance can endure

leading in only 51 of those Assembly segments – 50 fewer than the number it had won in 2022.

The timing made the 2024 general election result extremely significant. It followed the inauguration of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, which was the culmination of a political and cultural project that had animated the BJP and the wider Hindu right for decades. Yet, the inauguration did not produce the electoral impact that might have been expected: most strikingly, the BJP lost the Faizabad seat, which includes Ayodhya itself. It also lost in many constituencies around it. This does not mean that Ayodhya or the majoritarian politics surrounding it has ceased to matter. The consequential point is that it was no longer enough to win elections even in the movement's heartland. The fact that the erosion was most visible in this region adds to its significance, given the subsequent controversy over donations to the temple. The episode, whose effects are still being felt across the State, showed that even powerful ideological symbols are not beyond questions of integrity.

This matters because the BJP's political hold in U.P. has rested on a combination of communal mobilisation, a durable electoral base and social coalitions built around the temple campaign. The 2024 general election showed that this alignment could be disrupted. Its longer-term implications will depend on whether that disruption proves temporary or marks a lasting shift in the electorate's preferences and expectations.

Some of the prominent fault lines

The 2024 result also suggests that voters are becoming less willing to let a single dimension of politics overwhelm all others, especially when claims of economic performance do not match the realities on the ground. U.P. remains among the poorer-performing economies of the north and east – as it has for decades. Its economy has grown, but growth has not fundamentally altered its relative economic position or generated enough productive employment. The gap between the rhetoric of transformation and economic experience on the ground is particularly visible in the State's industrial clusters. In Kanpur, Firozabad, Bhadohi and Moradabad, exporters have faced serious disruption from the tariff regime of the United States, and the duties raised on Indian goods, with falling orders, shrinking market access and risks to employment, principally among temporary and contract workers.

The frustration among young voters is strikingly evident in the precarity of employment and recruitment. Many were actively involved in the anti-National Eligibility cum Entrance Test

that remained legal in Europe. Sanctions against Russia widened after 2022. Export controls pursued foreign suppliers of chips and machine tools. Oil restrictions reached tankers, insurers, ship managers and traders. Sanctions increasingly followed the transaction rather than stopping with the seller. On September 16, the U.S. Congress passed a sanctions bill that would authorise the U.S. President to impose tariffs as a form of economic coercion. Indian exports to the U.S. could face tariffs of up to 100% over India's purchases of Russian oil. The Indian government is monitoring developments and has said that it will work with industry to protect India's trade and economic interests.

Iran is using a different chokepoint at sea. On August 23, its Persian Gulf Strait Authority published a list of 45 vessels it called non-compliant. They included *Disha*, chartered by Petronet LNG and managed by the Shipping Corporation of India, and *Maha Roos*, an Indian-flagged bulk carrier. The authority did not explain the alleged breaches. By September 14, the list had grown to 77. The authority also warned insurers against covering listed ships. Washington has already sanctioned the authority and warned that seeking passage guarantees from it could carry sanctions risks, even without payment.

The domestic consequences

Economic coercion ties foreign policy directly to the domestic economy. Its consequences reach households, farmers and seafarers. No Ministry can see the whole chain on its own.

During the current West Asia crisis, the government coordinated Ministries, monitored vessels and supplies, raised LPG production and found alternative cargoes. It has kept pumps open and kitchens supplied.

That coordination should survive the crisis. An Economic Security and Sanctions Office under the Cabinet Secretariat should become India's permanent war room for economic coercion. It should bring together officials responsible for foreign policy, finance, commerce, energy, shipping, law and defence, alongside the Reserve

protests earlier in the year. U.P. has seen repeated examination leaks and cancellations. In 2024, the police constable examination, taken by around 48 lakh candidates for 60,244 posts, was cancelled following a paper leak. The Review Officer/Assistant Review Officer examination was similarly cancelled amid allegations of irregularities, where out of a total of 10.76 lakh registered candidates, about 6.8 lakh candidates appeared, competing for just 411 posts. For a generation that invests years in its preparation for scarce government jobs, such failures are not merely administrative lapses. They can mean the loss of money spent on coaching and applications, income and opportunity in a State where government employment remains a highly valued path to economic security.

The battle lines are being drawn

In these circumstances, the 2027 U.P. election is likely to be more closely contested than those that the BJP has faced in the State in recent years. The party remains the strongest contender, but the 2024 result has opened space for the Opposition and revealed strains at various levels that were barely perceptible in earlier elections. The government is working overtime to address the gap on several fronts, reflected in a slew of measures to promote local entrepreneurship and provide stipends for students in corporate and technical institutions.

It is also set to introduce new schemes for women, such as the Mahila Udyami Credit Yojana, under which around one crore women associated with self-help groups are expected to receive interest-free credit of up to ₹1 lakh in stages. The Opposition, too, sees an opening. Both the SP and the Congress are seeking to strengthen their appeal among younger voters, with their leaders, Akhilesh Yadav and Rahul Gandhi, focusing on student unrest, unemployment and widening caste fault lines, particularly divisions among upper castes and between them and the Other Backward Classes. Convergence between the two parties, as in 2024, could bolster the Opposition's chances in the 2027 U.P. election.

The 2027 election will therefore reveal more than the BJP's ability to recover lost seats. It will show whether the political template that carried the party to power from Lucknow to New Delhi still commands the same electoral force. The 2024 result has already shown that this template is no longer invulnerable in U.P. The 2027 election will determine whether the shift revealed in 2024 becomes more durable. What happens in U.P. could therefore alter the political balance on which the BJP's national dominance has rested.

A war room for India in an age of sanctions



Syed Akbaruddin

Former Permanent Representative of India to the United Nations and, currently, Dean, Kautilya School of Public Policy, Hyderabad

A coordinated response is essential as sanctions increasingly target entire transactions

that remained legal in Europe. Sanctions against Russia widened after 2022. Export controls pursued foreign suppliers of chips and machine tools. Oil restrictions reached tankers, insurers, ship managers and traders. Sanctions increasingly followed the transaction rather than stopping with the seller. On September 16, the U.S. Congress passed a sanctions bill that would authorise the U.S. President to impose tariffs as a form of economic coercion. Indian exports to the U.S. could face tariffs of up to 100% over India's purchases of Russian oil. The Indian government is monitoring developments and has said that it will work with industry to protect India's trade and economic interests.

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That coordination should survive the crisis. An Economic Security and Sanctions Office under the Cabinet Secretariat should become India's permanent war room for economic coercion. It should bring together officials responsible for foreign policy, finance, commerce, energy, shipping, law and defence, alongside the Reserve

Bank of India and market regulators. Its staff should track where transactions could fail, from payment and insurance to shipping and delivery.

It would seek evidence behind foreign listings, support legitimate requests for removal, negotiate written exemptions and transition periods, and issue clear Indian guidance. Banks should distinguish legal prohibitions from their own commercial caution. Companies should be warned early when a payment route, insurer or port is at risk.

India also needs more LPG storage, an expanded Indian-controlled tanker fleet and a stronger Bharat Maritime Insurance Pool, while securing long-term LNG contracts outside Hormuz. Rupee settlement can preserve lawful trade when sellers accept it, but cannot shield a bank that still needs New York.

Why India cannot follow China's stand

China has said that the American measures had no basis in international law or authorisation from the United Nations Security Council (UNSC). Earlier in May, Beijing told Chinese businesses not to recognise, enforce or comply with American sanctions against five Chinese refining companies. India also says that it upholds sanctions mandated by the UNSC and does not accept unilateral sanctions. That does not mean Delhi can simply copy Beijing. China's market power, state-directed economy and leverage over critical supply chains give it more room to resist.

India's financial and commercial ties with the U.S. make adopting Beijing's approach costly. A legal objection alone offers little comfort if Indian firms still bear the cost. India must protect household energy, seafarers, fertilizer supplies and lawful trade while preserving ties with the U.S., Russia, Iran and the Gulf. Delhi needs the full picture in one room before it acts.

The first test of sovereignty happens when Delhi decides. The second comes when that decision meets a New York bank or the Strait of Hormuz. In the age of sanctions, India cannot move those chokepoints. It can, however, make sure that every decision is taken with the whole journey in view.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Warnings about AI's perils

The concerns being expressed by some technology companies that artificial intelligence (AI) poses a threat to humanity cannot be ignored. There is no doubt that AI is making significant advances in critical sectors. Nevertheless, the possibility of its misuse by anti-national or anti-social

forces cannot be ruled out. At a time when cybercrimes are frequently reported, the abuse of AI in cyberspace could cause irreparable damage to society. The technology companies promoting AI must also provide a safety net to protect the global community from possible AI-related threats. Though superintelligence could be a

valuable servant of the public good, it could also become a dangerous master.

S. Seshadri,
Chennai

Deserving Phalke awardee Veteran Kannada actor Anant Nag richly deserves the Dadasaheb Phalke award. His effortless acting and flawless diction in

parallel and mainstream cinema are what have endeared him to his fans. His journey in life, from modest means to celebrity status, is inspiring.

Dr. Ganapathi Bhat,
Akola, Maharashtra

Celebrating bamboo

On World Bamboo Day, September 18, it is worth recognising a remarkable

plant that holds immense cultural and ecological value. Known variously as 'green gold' and 'poor man's timber', bamboo is an environmental powerhouse, with more than 1,500 species capable of thriving in diverse climates. Globally, bamboo is deeply woven into human traditions. Beyond its well-established traditional uses, it is a vital

ally in combating climate change. There must be greater awareness of the work of premier institutions such as India's Forest Research Centre for Bamboo and Rattan (FRCBR), in Aizawl, Mizoram.

M. Pradyu,
Thalikkavu, Kannur, Kerala

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Does the BRICS summit signify a shift for Indian foreign policy?



Ajay Bisaria
served as High Commissioner to Pakistan and Canada and is the author of 'Anger Management: The Troubled Diplomatic Relationship Between India and Pakistan'

PARLEY

With a strong pushback against unilateral western sanctions; criticism of Israel over the killing of civilians, the attacks on Lebanon, and the forced occupation of Palestinian territory; and support for UN reform as well as a BRICS payment mechanism, the New Delhi Declaration of 2026 has been likened to India's foreign policy from its non-aligned past. But was it a compromise by New Delhi to build consensus, or will the statement, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's close engagement with the leaders of Iran, Russia, and China, have a bearing on India's foreign policy? Ajay Bisaria and Happymon Jacob discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Suhasini Haidar**.

Is the New Delhi declaration a return to non-alignment or just momentary rhetoric?

Ajay Bisaria: Broadly, the declaration is in keeping with India's foreign policy, whether that is strategic autonomy and multi-alignment or multi-vector engagement. In terms of optics, India is more on the front foot and less apologetic than it used to be. India is getting more and more comfortable in a non-western forum, saying that it is emphatically part of it. While it doesn't necessarily mean a shift in posture, it does suggest a greater degree of comfort with a different set of optics.

Happymon Jacob: The BRICS summit is under spotlight and things under spotlight look bigger and shinier than they really are. BRICS is a political platform; not a security platform. I don't think India's policy today is that of non-alignment at all. Non-alignment was a strategy for a weak state in a bipolar world. Today, we are in a different kind of world and the desire in India is to become one of the poles in a multipolar world. There is a reference to the Bandung Spirit (Non-Aligned Movement) in the BRICS declaration in pursuit of a fairer, more inclusive, and representative multilateral system. But that is nostalgia, not real policy.

How important are optics such as the Modi-Xi-Putin handshakes or the Prime Minister reaching out to the Iranian President at a time when these leaders represent the “anti-Western lobby”?

HJ: The optics are, in some ways, the substance here. Chinese President Xi Jinping had not been to India in nearly seven years. And we had the Abu Dhabi Crown Prince (Khaled bin Zayed Al Nahyan) sitting at the same table. In some ways, the photograph is the message. At the BRICS



Russia's President Vladimir Putin, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and China's President Xi Jinping pose with other leaders during the BRICS Summit. AFP

outreach session, a lot of powers who don't otherwise get into great power conversations were present. So, there was a lot of socialisation happening inside the platform and on its margins. But I think we should understand that this is not really having an impact on how the world is being shaped. The declaration calls for exercising restraint and protecting civilians and civilian infrastructure and pointedly recalls the respective national positions of each member. It is fantastic, but the argument here is about optics, not common positions.

AB: I would agree that these multilateral fora are often performative to a degree and therefore all optics matter. But in a multilateral document, you can say the silent part aloud; what a country won't say in a national statement, it can say aloud in a high-level multilateral summit. For instance, everyone knows that the phrase “unilateral coercive measures” is about U.S. actions. So, you're not really saying we condemn U.S. action on so-and-so date; you're simply saying that we are against U.S. tariffs and [western] sanctions. There is an understanding now that what is said in a multilateral document can be different from a national position.

Every BRICS summit since 2022, including the 2024 summit in Russia, has made a reference to Ukraine. The New Delhi Declaration is the first time that references to Ukraine have been dropped. Why?

AB: My guess would be that it was a Russian veto. In the Rio BRICS declaration last year, there was even condemnation of a Ukrainian attack on Russia without an equivalent condemnation of anything Russia had done. So this time, instead of just condemning Ukraine, they might have decided to drop the whole thing entirely. It is very disappointing that a major multilateral geopolitical forum doesn't call for belligerents to end the war, but instead stays silent. That is an error of omission. I suspect the



Broadly, the Delhi declaration is in keeping with India's foreign policy, whether that is strategic autonomy and multi-alignment or multi-vector engagement

AJAY BISARIA

Russians said, no, we don't accept it, and in the interest of having a consensus, it was dropped.

HJ: I think India has no particular reason to push for that language to be present in the declaration because we have quite clearly sided with the Russian Federation in this war, indirectly if not directly. There must have been Russian push but I see no reason why there could not have been some neutral language to put in [references to Ukraine], given the precedent (of previous BRICS joint declarations).

The condemnation of Israel in the statement is very strong. Does this represent a shift for India given the PM's speech on standing “shoulder to shoulder” with Israel during his visit in February 2026?

AB: The big picture is that India is trying to establish neutral and balanced positions on both conflicts, and therefore not be seen as backing only one side in either. It has taken safety in the language of the United Nations. There's a specific mention of the UN Security Council Resolution 2803 of November last year, which spoke about an International Stabilisation Force and a Board of Peace. Some of the language has been drawn from there. The overall posture is: let's try to be balanced and reasonably neutral.

HJ: There is a clear disjunction between the statement and what Prime Minister Modi told the Israeli parliament. Perhaps the declaration is in some way intended to counter the perception that India was getting too close to Israel. The two-state solution has always been India's position, so the declaration doesn't contradict Indian policy there. But with the UAE, Egypt, Iran, and Indonesia in the room, there was only so much India could do to push back against the harshness of that language. What Prime Minister Modi told the Israelis in Israel is emotional and consequential. But what is written in the BRICS Declaration is multilateral, symbolic, and not very consequential. I would still say the balance is tilted in favour of Israel as a partner.

How significant are the paragraphs on economic issues, particularly on intra-BRICS trade using payments in national currencies? These 10 or 11 countries represent 40% of the

global economy, and 25% of global trade. Could they pose a challenge to the G7?

HJ: Indian policy has two parts. One is the support for local currency payment mechanisms. I don't think India has supported a permanent payment mechanism under the ambit of BRICS. I think there is an acknowledgement that there is no one-size-fits-all approach as far as currency settlement payment mechanisms are concerned. I would think twice before signing on to a non-U.S. dollar payment mechanism, which I believe will mean the next big currency or the next powerful currency. And unfortunately, China's currency is going to be that big currency.

AB: BRICS is a counterpoint to the G7, an economic grouping that also has geopolitical responsibilities. But I think India also finds itself at an intersection with the G7, because it is a sort of permanent invitee to the G7, along with Australia and South Korea. I have made the argument elsewhere that the G7 should dissolve itself and become the Democratic 10 (D10), including these three countries. I think that is the real strategic autonomy or multi-vector engagement, where India becomes the bridge between the east and the west, but also a voice of the south.

Will any of the decisions at BRICS see their way into future Indian foreign policy? Or is this just one moment with BRICS countries?

AB: I think this is a moment of success in Indian diplomacy in terms of conducting a major international event. In November, there will be another opportunity to meet global leaders at the ASEAN-East Asia Summit in the Philippines, followed by Prime Minister Modi's visits to the U.S., Canada, and Brussels, where he could potentially secure three trade agreements. I think that's what diplomacy will be about: multi-vector engagement; keeping all stakeholders engaged, in multiple directions.

HJ: India has only so much diplomatic capital. Therefore, it is important to pick our battles, forums, and partners. I think we should be present in those rooms where global rules on AI are being framed, and where the future of space governance is discussed. I don't think the next world order is going to be made in forums such as the BRICS but in those silent small rooms.



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NOTEBOOK

AI makes editors read the writer as well as the text

Editors are often caught between their duty to the readers and employers and the demands of the publishing process

Vasudevan Mukunth

I'm a commissioning editor. Every day, I receive more submissions of articles written by AI than the last. The same goes for articles polished by AI. More than going against *The Hindu's* policy, this habit has the potential to corrode the human practice of writing.

Writing is often hard. You consider the relationship between your intentions and the meaning of words laid down on a page. You think through using the many degrees of freedom a sentence or paragraph affords to convey precisely what you mean, down to the feeling, while also holding readers' attention and doing justice to yourself without becoming self-absorbed. Writing should trouble the mind. AI-made or -polished writing offers to take this trouble away – a temptation to be resisted.

AI-written or -polished text can be corrosive to readers as well because all such texts, no matter how diverse their contents, read the same way. Editing it to be more human, to have an undulating rhythm rather than that sterilised glaze, is also an exasperating experience.

I used to maintain a list of the hallmarks of AI-written or -polished text, but as they evolved, I turned to two 'detector' tools: GPTZero and Pangram. I trust them because of their favourable coverage in the scientific press, their developers' attitude towards the tools' role in the publishing enterprise, and their lower false-positive rates. A false positive is when a tool flags a piece as being AI-written when in reality it is not. It can be pernicious because it causes me to decline a submission I may have accepted, potentially disappointing an author. Such a result may also cause editors to develop an unfavourable opinion of such contributors.

Sometimes, these tools jointly return very high or very low scores, allowing me to decide quickly about accepting or declining submissions. The problem arises when one or both tools return a middling score, e.g. “50% chance of being written by AI” or “50% of the text is written by AI”.

In these instances, I need to negotiate a way forward. If the author is a rookie, I may insist on seeing the timestamped version history of the document containing their text, and ensure the words didn't suddenly appear all at once. (If I have doubts at the time of commissioning itself, I may insist the author quote some experts firsthand and submit their reporting notes together with the finished article.) If I have a mature relationship with an author, I directly communicate the stakes and possible courses of action.

But when an author doesn't tick these convenient boxes, I need to draft a reply that balances several sensibilities. First, I must not offend them. In fact, I have no intention of villainising them: people use AI models with text for various reasons, only a small subset of which are malicious. Second, I need to elicit from the author an honest response about whether, and if so how, they used AI – especially a reply I can be sure is unencumbered by insecurities or second-guessing. Third, I need to keep the author's trust while maintaining that I cannot accept AI-written or -polished text. Fourth, I must justify, if required, my decision to repose my trust in those tools rather than in my judgment and/or in our relationship alone.

Now, if GPTZero and Pangram independently falsely flag 5 out of every 100 articles as being AI-written or -polished, they will have a combined false positive rate of just 1 in 4 million. However, the chance of one tool flagging an article right and the other flagging it wrong is still 1 in 1,000, which is much higher.

But I cannot make decisions with mathematics alone as my guide. AI has caused me to think more closely about the author submitting an article and their reasons to use – or not use – AI. Similarly, it would help if authors think more closely about editors, who are caught between their duty to their readers and employers on one hand and to facilitate the publishing process on the other.

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Chasing the sunset



Golden hour: Trained swimmers accompany a Ganesha idol which is to be immersed in the Krishna River downstream of the Prakasam Barrage in Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh following the Ganesh Chaturthi festivities on September 16. The immersion was carried out at a designated stretch of the river. G.N. RAO

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 18, 1976

Bright future for computers in India

Hyderabad, September 17: Prof. A.S. Douglas, Professor of Computational Methods, London School of Economics and Vice-President, International Federation of Information Processing told *The Hindu* here to-day that computer technology would have considerable future in developing countries like India as it aided the planning process in various spheres. He said that computers could be used for highly sophisticated calculations in

The *Hindu*

scientific and technical matters as well as simple calculations in physics and chemistry.

Prof. Douglas said that while there were certain jobs which could be done efficiently by men, there were many things which computers could perform more efficiently and quickly than human beings. It was necessary that a happy balance should be maintained in the choice of jobs that could be performed by men and those that could be entrusted to computers.

Prof. Douglas, who was delivering a lecture under the auspices of the Hyderabad Chapter of the Computer Society of India, said that India should have a well-organised programme for the training of personnel needed for manning the computers.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 18, 1926

A lecture on advertising

Under the auspices of the Students' Economical Association the inaugural address was delivered yesterday evening by Prof. Jospeh France of the Presidency College, in the Senate House. The meeting was well attended. The Chairman in his opening remarks said that India was lacking in the art of advertisements. Owing to the neglect of this branch of study most of the Indian industries were not well-known. Best of their products found no place in the advertising field, whereas they found so many minor products of the west advertised through newspapers.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Increase in Indian utilities' August coal imports

5.52 million metric tonnes. Indian power producers' coal imports in August rose to a 15-month high as a heatwave and lower hydropower generation boosted electricity demand. Coal imports jumped 85.6% year-on-year to 5.52 million metric tonnes. REUTERS

Number of deceased persons returned to Ukraine by Russia

252 Ukraine has received the bodies of 252 people in an exchange of war dead with Russia, Ukrainian authorities said on Thursday. Russia received 23 bodies in return, Russian lawmaker Shamsail Saraliev was quoted as saying by the RBK news outlet. AFP

Private capital attracted by the World Bank

112 in \$ billion. The World Bank on Thursday said it attracted \$112 billion in private capital in the year ended June versus \$69 billion a year earlier, and more than triple the amount in fiscal 2022 before former Mastercard CEO Ajay Banga became president. REUTERS

Amount to be spent on defence by Ukraine in 2027

4.9 in trillion hryvnia. The Ukrainian government plans to spend two-thirds of its budget on defence next year. Russia's four-and-a-half-year offensive has battered Ukraine's economy, causing billions of dollars in destruction and punching a huge hole in its neighbour's finances. AFP

Number of taluks declared drought-hit in Karnataka

124 The Karnataka government on Thursday declared 23 more taluks drought-affected, taking the total number of drought-hit taluks notified so far to 124, amid dry conditions in several parts of the State. PTI
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What is the Uniform Civil Code debate?

How are personal laws governed today? What does the Constitution say about a UCC? What are the arguments in favour of a UCC? What are the arguments against? How could a UCC guarantee equal women's rights? What alternative has been proposed?

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

Union Home Minister Amit Shah has indicated that the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would be implemented in all 21 NDA-ruled States by 2029. Uttarakhand has had a UCC in force since January 2025, while UCC bills passed by the legislatures of Assam, Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh are awaiting Presidential assent.

How are personal matters governed today?

Article 44 of the Constitution provides that the State shall endeavour to secure a UCC for citizens throughout India. A UCC would apply the same set of secular personal laws to all people, irrespective of religion, caste, or tribe. India already has uniform criminal laws and common civil laws covering matters such as taxation, contracts, and negotiable instruments.

However, in matters such as marriage, divorce, and inheritance of property, various religious communities in India follow personal laws that are based on their religious doctrines. Hindus are governed by laws such as the Hindu Marriage Act (1955) and the Hindu Succession Act (1956), while many tribals within the Hindu religion may follow customary family laws under constitutional exceptions. Jains, Buddhists and Sikhs are covered by Hindu laws. Sikh marriages can also be registered under the Anand Marriage Act (2012). Christians and Parsis have their own personal laws, while Muslims are governed by the Muslim Personal Law (Shariat) Application Act (1937).

What are the pros and cons?

The Constitution makers were divided over including a UCC in the Constitution.



GETTY IMAGES

Some wanted it to be made a Fundamental Right to ensure uniformity in civil laws and secure equal rights for women. However, many members of the Muslim community were not in favour of including it in the Constitution as they felt that a uniform civil code would violate the fundamental right to religion that is guaranteed in Part III. Finally, the provision relating to UCC was placed in the non-justiciable Part IV - Directive Principles of State Policy.

There are several arguments over aspects of the UCC. The key arguments in its favour are, first, that it would make India secular in the true sense by subjecting all citizens to the same personal laws. The second and most vital argument is gender justice: a UCC would ensure equal rights for women across religions in matters governed by personal laws.

The key arguments against UCC are as follows. First, there can be potential conflict between the provisions of the UCC and guaranteed fundamental rights. Article 25 of the Constitution guarantees every person a fundamental right to practise a religion of one's choice. Article 29 provides a fundamental right to any section of citizens to conserve their distinct culture. The provisions of a UCC on personal matters may run contrary to scriptures and cultural doctrines in a religion. Second, the four States that have enacted UCC have exempted tribal population from its ambit. The reasons for such exemption are constitutional safeguards to protect tribal culture as well as the belief that many tribal customs in these matters provide adequate rights to women. However, exempting one section of society while making it compulsory for all other groups, including religious

minorities, is discriminatory.

What can be the way forward?

The most important reason to reform civil laws is to ensure equal rights for women in matters of marriage, divorce, maintenance, and inheritance. The right to religion under Article 25 is subject to constitutional morality and other fundamental rights, including equality. In Section 6A of the Citizenship Act, 1955 (2024) case, the Supreme Court held that practices such as casteism and gender discrimination, which run against the spirit of the Constitution, would not receive protection under Article 29. Thus, reforms in personal laws should not be viewed as violating Articles 25 and 29, as they uphold women's equality, an essential facet of constitutional morality.

However, there is resistance to the UCC among minorities, particularly Muslims. In the Constituent Assembly, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar advocated a UCC but suggested that it could remain voluntary. He said Parliament could provide for the UCC to apply to citizens who declare they are willing to be bound by it.

On the other hand, the Law Commission in its Consultation Paper on Reform of Family Law (2018) opined that a UCC was neither necessary nor desirable at this stage. It argued instead for reforming discriminatory provisions across personal laws. The emphasis should be on achieving 'equality within communities' between men and women rather than 'equality between communities.' The report recommends legislative reforms required in various personal laws with respect to marriage, divorce, custody, adoption, maintenance, succession and inheritance, that would ensure gender justice. The suggestions of the Law Commission should be considered while legislating and implementing reforms in personal laws. (Rangarajan R is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified'. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

▼ The Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would replace religion-based personal laws governing matters such as marriage, divorce and inheritance with a common set of secular laws

▼ Supporters argue that it would promote secularism, national integration and gender justice, while critics point to possible conflicts with religious and cultural rights

▼ The Law Commission has instead favoured reforming discriminatory provisions in existing personal laws to ensure equality between men and women

Why was ex-Kosovo President convicted by The Hague?

What was Thaci's role in the Kosovo Liberation Army? How has the verdict been received?

Joan Sony Cherian

The story so far:

Hashim Thaci, the former President of Kosovo, has been sentenced to 25 years in prison after being found guilty of war crimes by a special European Union-backed court at The Hague. The trial found him guilty of war crimes including murder, arbitrary detention, illegal arrests, torture, etc during the Kosovo war in the late 1990s as a senior commandant of the Kosovo Liberation Army (KLA). Three other former KLA commanders were also sentenced for several different charges.

What happened?

Thaci was a former commandant of the KLA, a militant ethnic Albanian force, formed in the early 1990s, which strove for the independence of Kosovo, composed primarily of ethnic Albanians, from Yugoslavia and Serbia.

Kosovo was once part of the erstwhile Republic of Yugoslavia. After the Second World War, the Kingdom of Yugoslavia

was reconstituted as the Socialist Federal Republic of Yugoslavia under the leadership of Josip Broz Tito. While Tito was able to unify the multiple republics, including Croatia, Montenegro, Serbia, Slovenia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and Macedonia, and the autonomous provinces of Kosovo and Vojvodina, under a centralised government, the system came under pressure after his death. Multiple factors, including divisions between the republics, rising nationalist movements, economic pressures, and the disintegration of the Soviet Union, contributed to Yugoslavia's eventual dissolution in 2003.

One of the primary nationalist trends that spearheaded Yugoslavian dissolution was the Serbian nationalist movement led by Slobodan Milošević in the late 1980s. Riding on Serbian nationalist tendencies, Milošević pushed through policies that stripped other republics and provinces, such as Kosovo, of their autonomy. He also brought in policies that were discriminatory in nature against Albanians.

The KLA was formed in this

atmosphere to fight for the independence of ethnic Albanians in Kosovo, then a province within Serbia. The KLA led an insurgency against the Yugoslav state, attacking Serbian government buildings and police stations. This eventually led to an all-out war in 1998-1999, with the Serbian-controlled federal republic brutally cracking down on the KLA. The war led to the displacement of thousands of people and the death of nearly 13,000 people, mostly ethnic Albanians. The war finally ended with the intervention of NATO (the North Atlantic Treaty Organization), which carried out air raids and bombardments against Serbian targets, which forced the federal republic to end hostilities and move out of Kosovo. NATO subsequently deployed peacekeeping forces to the region.

Milošević eventually stood trial for his crimes against humanity, genocide, and war crimes committed during the Yugoslav Wars of the 1990s, in The Hague in 2002. However, he died in prison before a judgment was reached.

In 2008, Kosovo declared independence from Serbia and was

recognised by the U.S. and several other European nations. However, Serbia does not recognise Kosovo as an independent nation and still considers it a part of itself even though it has no administrative control over it. It is still not a member state of the UN. India also does not recognise Kosovo as an independent nation.

What was the trial for?

The trial was heard by the European Union-backed Kosovo Specialist Chambers, a special tribunal court constituted in The Hague in 2016, to hear the crimes committed by the KLA during the period of insurgency and subsequent war of the 1990s. The need for such a tribunal arose after Swiss politician Dick Marty authored a Council of Europe report, known as the Marty report, in 2010, which alleged that the KLA placed many Serbians in secret detention centres where they were subjected to inhuman and degrading treatment, before ultimately "disappearing". Of particular note was the allegation that the KLA had harvested the organs of such prisoners to sell them in the international market.

The report, in effect, coloured the larger imagination of the KLA and the Kosovo independence movement. The narrative changed from the KLA being seen as a champion of self-determination to an inhumane militia which had committed human rights abuses against Serbian nationals.

At least 15 people have been charged by the Chambers, with Thaci being the most senior figure. Charges were brought

against him in 2020, when he was President of Kosovo, following which he had to resign and stand trial as an ordinary citizen. The central question before the court was to understand the extent of the commandants' control over the KLA and whether the crimes amounted to a pattern of abuse. Finally, presiding judge Charles Smith stated that Thaci had "actively participated in and encouraged crimes," adding that "the scale and nature of the crimes committed were very serious". However, the judge insisted that the trial was "not about the legitimacy of the Kosovo Liberation Army" or its ultimate goal of securing independence for Kosovo.

What has been the reaction?

The verdict is a significant fall for Thaci, who was once regarded by Western powers as central to Kosovo's post-war future. In Kosovo, where Thaci is still seen as a revolutionary figure, the verdict was met with outrage and tears. Kosovo's Prime Minister Albin Kurti said the verdict was "a travesty of justice". People who had poured into the streets of Pristina, the capital of Kosovo, to hear the verdict were shocked and shouted slogans in support of the KLA and Thaci.

However, the Serbian side has welcomed the judgement. Serbia's Deputy Prime Minister Ivica Dacic called the verdicts a "warning" to Pristina "that a fake state cannot be built on mass graves of murdered Serbs".

Thaci and the three other commandants have the right to appeal the decision.

EXPLAINER



Merchant Discount Rate is a fee for using UPI that will be paid by merchants to payment processors and banks. REUTERS

Who has to pay MDR on UPI and who stands to gain the most?

Merchant Discount Rate will apply to certain P2M transactions above ₹2,000, while P2P transactions and merchant payments up to ₹2,000 will remain free; the charge will be shared among banks and UPI apps, with exemptions and caps limiting the transactions and amount that attract MDR

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan

The story so far: After much speculation and debate, the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has finally released its circular about the additional charges it will allow to be levied on certain UPI payments from October 15. While the Opposition has argued that this charge will increase prices for consumers, the government has argued that this will not happen, and that even the impact on merchants will be minimal.

Who will have to pay the MDR charge? Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) is a fee for using UPI that will be paid by merchants to payment processors and banks. Consumers will not have to directly pay the MDR. In its press release relating to the NPCI's announcement, the Ministry of Finance on September 15 emphasised that banks have been advised to ensure that merchants do not pass MDR charges on to customers and that UPI application providers are expressly prohibited from imposing platform fees or hidden charges on users.

The MDR will have to be paid by mid-to large-sized merchants who receive UPI payments in excess of ₹2,000 per transaction. These merchants will have to pay a charge of 0.4%. For transactions of ₹75,000 and above, the MDR will be capped at ₹300 per transaction.

However, the rules change when it comes to essential sectors. Transactions of ₹2,000 or more in essential and thin-margin sectors, such as railways, telecommunications, insurance, fuel, and agricultural inputs, will attract a flat MDR of ₹5 per transaction.

According to the government, this flat charge will provide cost certainty for critical public services and businesses operating on narrow margins. Further, capital market transactions such as payments to mutual funds, stockbrokers, dealers, and for equities will attract an MDR of 0.02%, capped at ₹300 per transaction. This lower rate, the government has argued, is aimed at supporting retail participation in formal financial markets.

One way to ascertain how widespread the charge will be is to look at the volumes of UPI transactions. An analysis by *The Hindu* of data provided by the NPCI shows that person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions above ₹2,000 make up just 2.5% of all UPI transactions by volume.

Who will not have to pay? All Person-to-Person (P2P) transactions will remain free of charge, regardless of the amount being transferred. The government has specified that “no transaction fee, platform fee or other charge may be imposed on individuals for sending or receiving money through UPI”. This is a significant exemption because P2P UPI transactions make up about 37% of the total UPI transaction volume.

Further, payments to merchants up to ₹2,000 will remain free of MDR. This makes up another 60.5% of all UPI transactions by volume. That means, in total, 97.5% of all UPI transactions will remain free.

In addition, the NPCI has mandated that small merchants, including street vendors receiving up to ₹1 lakh per month through UPI QR codes under the Person-to-Person-Merchant (P2PM) category, will also be exempt from MDR.

This means that the proportion of UPI payments that will attract a charge is actually even smaller than 2.5%.

Who stands to gain the most? The government has said that the MDR will be shared among payment ecosystem participants, including banks, payment service providers, and UPI application providers.

The analysis of the NPCI data shows that the P2M transactions above ₹2,000 make up 20% of all UPI transactions by value.

That is, while ₹29.8 lakh crore was transacted over UPI in August 2026, P2M transactions above ₹2,000 were ₹5.99 lakh crore. This means that the absolute maximum that banks and payment processors can earn from MDR is about ₹2,400 crore a month (0.4% of ₹5.99 lakh crore) or ₹28,000 crore a year. However, since there are multiple caveats, exemptions, flat rates, and caps imposed, the total amount receivable will be lower than this.

The way MDR works is that the bulk of

the charge (about 40% of what is collected) goes to the payer's bank since it holds the customer's bank account and bears the core authorisation, security, and settlement costs of the transaction.

Here, Yes Bank is the undisputed gainer, since it is the payer bank in more than 50% of all UPI transactions. The second largest is ICICI Bank at 18.3%.

Of the MDR collected, the merchant's bank or receiving bank receives 30%. This is because they manage the merchant's relationship, handle the QR code deployment, and process merchant settlements.

Here, too, Yes Bank is the payee in about 55% of all UPI transactions and so stands to earn the most from the MDR, followed by Axis Bank at about 19%.

Another 20% of the MDR goes to the UPI app or Third-Party Application Provider (TPAP). PhonePe and Google Pay stand to benefit from this, since PhonePe accounts for about 46% of UPI transactions by volume and Google Pay another 32%.

The final 10% of the MDR goes to the Payment Service Provider that connects the technology partner bank that connects the UPI application to the central network switches.

The government has also said that a dedicated fund will be established to promote UPI adoption among small merchants, with an amount equivalent to 5% of total MDR collections contributed to this fund. It does not specify from which of the payment system players this 5% will be taken.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

How do you refer to the years between 1901 and 1910? Is there a single word for it? (Subhkaran Choradia, Nagaur, Rajasthan) No, there isn't. There is no word to refer to something that happened in the first or the second decade of a particular century. People generally tend to say the 'early decades' of the Twentieth Century. We can, for example, say 'the early 1900s', or the first/second decade of the Twentieth Century. It is, however, possible to refer to something that happened after 1920. For example, the years between 1920 and 1930 are usually referred to as the 1920s. Similarly, we have the 1930s, 1940s, etc. If we know which century we are talking about, then we may simply say the 40s, the 50s, etc. It is important to note, however, that there is no apostrophe after the year. We do not generally write '1930's'; it would be wrong to do so.

What is a female "postmaster" called? (A. Ambar, Chennai) A woman who is in charge of a local post office is called a 'postmistress'. Makes sense, doesn't it? The plural is 'postmistresses'. These words have been included in the latest edition of some dictionaries. Ever wondered what a female postman is called? Logically, it should be 'postwoman', but none of the dictionaries have included this word. In the U.S., men and women who deliver mail are called "mail carriers".

What is the meaning of "stand someone up"? (V. S. Narayan, Kakinada) This is an expression which is frequently used in informal contexts. When you 'stand someone up', you make an appointment with the individual and then fail to show up. The expression is normally used when one fails to keep a date with one's boyfriend or girlfriend. If your boss doesn't keep his appointment, you don't generally say that the boss stood you up! Unless, of course, your boss happens to be your significant other. *Sunita stood Raju up. He was extremely angry.*

How is the word "roulette" pronounced? (B. Srinivasan, Chennai) The 'ou' in the first syllable is like the 'oo' in 'ool', 'pool', and 'cool', while the 'e' in the second syllable sounds like the 'e' in 'set', 'pet', and 'let'. The final 'e' is silent and the main stress is on the second syllable. Any idea what "roulette" is? It is a gambling game in which a wheel (roulette) spins round and round and you have to predict which number the ball or marble will land on. Then of course we have Russian roulette. Ever heard of this game? Well, it's not actually a game. What you do is put a bullet into one of the chambers of a gun, leaving the remaining five chambers empty. You then keep spinning the chambers till you are no longer sure where the bullet is. Next you place the gun on your head and pull the trigger. If you are lucky, you survive; otherwise....

Some people get a lot of thrill playing such games. Gabbar Singh in Sholay enjoyed playing Russian roulette. The expression 'playing Russian roulette' has begun to be used metaphorically as well. When you say that someone is 'playing Russian roulette', what you are implying is that he/she is taking terrible risks; doing something very, very dangerous. *Published in The Hindu on January 1, 2002*

Word of the day

Adulation: servile flattery; exaggerated and hypocritical praise

Synonyms: adoration, worship, appreciation, idolisation

Usage: *The actor received adulation from his fans.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/adulation

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ədʒʊleɪʃən/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Text & Context'

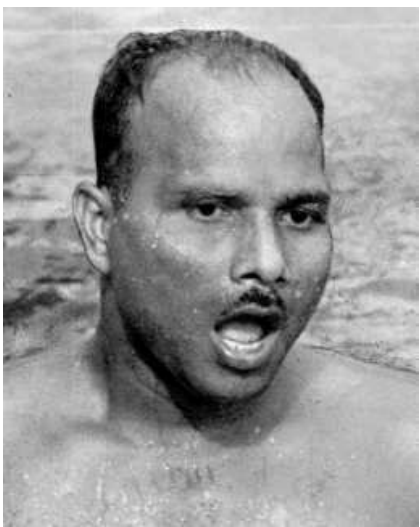
THE DAILY QUIZ

Test yourself on the Indian odyssey at the Asian Games ahead of the 20th edition starting in Aichi-Nagoya on Saturday

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1** It is well known that the Asian Games debuted in New Delhi in 1951. What is the only other time India has played host to the Games?
- QUESTION 2** With a gold medal at every edition and 779 medals overall, India is the fifth-most successful country at the Games. In which Games did it cross the 100 medal mark with 107?
- QUESTION 3** The most successful Indian athlete at the Games has 11 medals, including four golds at a single edition. Who and in which Games did the legend win four golds?

- QUESTION 4** Mohamed Anas Imran Beg, Declan Marshall Gonsalves and Quimcy Dsouza are representing India in which sport that is making its debut in 2026?
- QUESTION 5** In which sport has India been dominant, with the men winning eight out of the nine editions since the sport's debut in 1990 and the women four out of five since 2010?
- QUESTION 6** Which sport follows athletics (283 medals, including 85 gold) for the most medals for India with 80, including 16 gold?
- QUESTION 7** Who is set to become the first Indian sportsperson to feature at seven straight Asian Games?



Visual Question: Name this swimmer who won India's first-ever gold medal at the inaugural Games. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

- Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:** 1. Thaci was convicted by the Kosovo Specialist Chambers of The Hague. What is the mandate? **Ans: Its hearing trials of crimes committed by members of the Kosovo Liberation Army during the 1998-99 war**
2. Which sitting PM currently has an arrest warrant against him issued by the International Criminal Court in 2024? **Ans: Benjamin Netanyahu, Prime Minister of Israel**
3. This British supermodel once testified in a trial against this former Liberian president at the Special Court for Sierra Leone in The Hague. **Ans: Naomi Campbell; Charles Taylor**
4. In 2023, the ICC issued an arrest warrant against Russian President Vladimir Putin for war crimes in Ukraine. It also issued a warrant for another Russian official. Name the individual. **Ans: Maria Alekseyevna Lvova-Belova**
5. In 2016, this leader was convicted by the ICC to 18 years' imprisonment for war crimes and crimes against humanity committed in the Central African Republic. However, the leader was ultimately acquitted by the court after an appeal. Name the leader and his current position. **Ans: Jean-Pierre Bemba Gombo; Deputy PM of Transportation and Channels of Communication of the Democratic Republic of Congo**
- Visual: This leader became the first ex-head of state to stand trial before an international court since World War II. **Ans: Slobodan Milosevic**
- Early Birds:** K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Sunil Madhavan | Piyali Tuli | Arun Kumar Singh

Quarantine boxes to luxury cabins, China’s prefab home factories pivot to exports



Surging exports: The cheapest, container-like houses have a pre-shipping cost of less than \$1,000. VIA REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
BEIJING/HONG KONG

Sun Guangqing’s prefabricated homes factory in China opened in 2022 just as the property sector entered a prolonged crisis and only months before Beijing lifted pandemic curbs, developments that crippled its two main sources of demand.

For Hebei Shengtai Integrating Housing, survival required a rapid pivot. The company moved beyond container-style quarantine units and temporary worker accommodation to produce more stylish prefab homes aimed at export markets.

“Any factory wants to survive,” said Sun, 41, the head of production and design at the factory in the northern city of Hengshui. “When domestic sales plunge, factories must find other markets and foreign markets are larger.”

He says most of his industry peers are now making capsule homes and luxurious foldable cabins for the tourism and vacation property industries overseas, showcasing the ability of the world’s largest manufacturing base to rapidly adapt and upgrade its products for consumers abroad.

Prefab exports surge
China’s prefabricated building exports rose to \$4.3 billion in 2025 from \$1.7 billion in 2020, with the U.S., Southeast Asia, Australia, and Western Europe as key markets, customs data show.

While that is just a fraction of China’s massive \$1.2 trillion trade surplus last year, the industry’s shift from domestic to foreign sales is emblematic of a post-pandemic export boom that worried Western capitals dub ‘China shock 2.0’.

China’s export juggernaut, which the West fears is gutting local industries and torching jobs, will dominate the agenda at a summit between U.S. President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping next week.

Expectations for the meeting are modest, though, not least because Beijing has grown increasingly self-assured that no rival can match its industrial machine for scale and efficiency, demonstrating its ability to expand in foreign markets despite steeper tariffs.

For Sun, the fiercest competition comes not from foreign rivals but from the more than 1,000 prefab-home factories across China. Hengshui alone has around 30. He is unfazed by the prospect of additional trade barriers, because other countries “genuinely have the demand” and “our production speed and efficiency right now are something no other country can match.”

His firm builds a home in as little as 15 to 25 days and delivers it overseas within three months. Comparable homes produced locally in many markets often take far longer and cost more, he said.

China’s export boom “is happening regardless of tariffs, geopolitical instability, logistics disruptions, oil prices and all sorts of political narratives,” said Hao Dong, senior lecturer in management at the University of Southampton.

Perceptions of “Made in China” products are improving noticeably, he said.

“I cannot imagine anything that would effectively stop the trend, except for extremely radical developments such as wars,”he added.

Local supply chains
June Liu, a saleswoman at Qingdao Jingcheng Metal Technology, which sells factory-built homes from Weifang in eastern China, said domestic manufacturers enjoy a cost edge from cheaper labour, integrated local supply chains and large-scale production.

Steel structures, insulation panels, doors, windows and other parts are all available in and around her city of 9 million, while the port of Qingdao is only a two-hour drive away.

“It’s all nearby,” Liu said. “In Weifang, there’s one street where you drive for 20 minutes and all you see left and right is factories.”

The cheapest, container-like houses have a pre-shipping cost of less than 6,800 yuan (\$1,000), while A-frame double-wing homes cost more than 100,000 yuan, Liu said. Some clients want them equipped with furniture, water heaters, air conditioners and other appliances, which the firm sources from Chinese brands, including Hisense and Haier.

Fed builds credibility, but hawkish turn leaves global investors jittery

Fed raises rates for first time since 2023; unanimous vote seen as potentially hawkish signal; futures suggest odds of Oct. hike prior to U.S. midterms; following Wednesday’s Fed meeting, stocks fell, with the benchmark S&P 500 ending down 0.45% and yields on 2-year, 10-year Treasuries rising

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

Investors are gaining more confidence in the Federal Reserve’s inflation-fighting back bone, but uncertainty about how far it will raise interest rates to keep prices in check is likely to cause volatility for stocks and bonds in the weeks ahead.

The U.S. central bank on Wednesday raised rates for the first time since 2023, a widely expected move as it seeks to address persistently above-target inflation, despite repeated public calls by President Donald Trump for rate cuts.

But markets now confront a very different investment backdrop, including a lack of clarity about how tight the Fed will now seek to make monetary policy. In the face of higher rates, some investors said it could make rate-sensitive assets, such as small-cap stocks, less attractive.

The meeting “does make them look independent...it adds trust to the market,” said Matthew Miskin, co-chief investment strategist at Manulife John Hancock Investments.

Yet the Fed “may have come off a little too hawkish in this meeting and we’re just going to have to



Two can’t tango: U.S. President Donald Trump with Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh. REUTERS

see how the economy can react in the next couple of months,” he said.

Many investors saw the meeting as a test of independence for new Fed chair Kevin Warsh, who was picked by Trump.

“I hope at least at a very high level, one takeaway that investors have is economics is trumping politics at the Fed, at least for now,” said Marta Norton, chief investment strategist at retirement and wealth services firm Empower.

Unanimous vote
Higher rates stand to slow the economy by raising borrowing costs for consumers and firms and also could pose a head wind for the performance of stocks and other risk assets.

Markets entered 2026

unanimous, following the last meeting in July when the decision to hold rates steady was 9 to 3.

“A unanimous hike materially raises the probability of another move before year-end, and investors positioned for the easing cycle of early 2026 need to fully recalibrate,” said David Krakauer, vice president of portfolio management at MercerAdvisors.

Following Wednesday’s meeting, stocks fell, with the benchmark S&P 500 ending down 0.45%. Yields on two-year and 10-year Treasuries rose, with the benchmark 10-year yield at 5.02% late on Wednesday, above the closely watched 5% level. The U.S. dollar gained sharply against a basket of currencies.

“This meeting landed as pricing in rate cuts, but that flipped after the late-February U.S.-Israeli war with Iran drove up energy prices and inflation, shifting bets toward possible hikes.

Wednesday’s quarter-percentage-point hike lifted the Fed’s benchmark rate to 3.75-4.00%. Investors took note that the vote among Fed officials was

Maharashtra’s DELTA bet to tokenise India’s RWAs

Santosh V. Perumal

Token, which was merely a queue-management mechanism in the pre-millennial generation, has now become a powerful instrument of financial innovation. Powered by blockchain and distributed ledger technology (DLT), a token is a digital representation of ownership, value or rights.

The proposed Digitisation and Exchange of Land Token Assets (DELTA) Act, which will make Maharashtra the country’s first “tokenised State”, marks a significant shift in India’s digital economy and its race towards tokenising RWAs or real world assets.

The DELTA Act, which is bound to go through legal and legislative rigour, can make tokens legally enforceable instruments. Theoretically, the objective is to convert physical asset ownership and economic rights into secure digital representations which unlock wealth, improve transparency and ease transaction friction.

Land is among India’s largest repositories of wealth, even as a substantial portion is economically locked because transactions are slow, documentation is complex and ownership disputes are common.

Maharashtra’s land and property market is among the country’s largest, with the State government estimating the potential asset base under consideration at around ₹50 lakh crore.

The State is now preparing a legal framework to convert an existing asset’s ownership rights or economic value into digital tokens recorded on a blockchain. These tokens can represent fractions of an asset, enabling easier transfer, verification and potentially wider



Future perfect: Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis chairs a meeting on DELTA Act. @CMOMAHARASHTRA X

participation.

The initiative also aligns with its ambition to build a technology-driven economy and strengthen Mumbai’s position as a global financial and fintech hub.

DELTA Act could boost RWA tokenisation in India, which already has a robust digital public infrastructure such as Aadhaar, UPI and account aggregator.

Just as UPI eased friction in payments, tokenisation could do so in asset transactions by enabling faster verification, transparent ownership history, reduced fraud, automated compliance and efficient settlement.

The power of RWA tokenisation is in connecting physical assets with financial markets. Here comes the significance of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), headquartered in Mumbai.

The apex bank – which has already implemented tokenisation in card payments, replacing actual card details with secure digital tokens to boost safety – takes a pragmatic approach as it does not view tokenisation as a substitute for regulated finance as DELTA’s core principle is asset-backed digital representation.

Rather, the banking regulator sees tokenisation as a technology layer to improve efficiency, even as concerns remain over legal enforceability of token ownership, investor protection, valuation standards, cybersecurity, and prevention of misuse for speculative activities.

RBI’s move
RBI has been exploring tokenisation of financial assets via initiatives such as Unified Markets Interface (UMI). The RBI and Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) have already moved towards testing tokenised corporate bonds via “Demat 2.0” pilot, combining DLT with digital settlement mechanisms. Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India recently facilitated its first tokenised corporate bond issuance from IIFL Finance Ltd.

The International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) has initiated consultation on a regulatory approach for tokenisation of RWAs, recognising opportunities and legal challenges. A well-regulated token framework would deepen capital markets and improve financial inclusion as it allows banks, mutual funds, alternative investment funds and institutional investors to access new asset classes.

If Maharashtra develops a legal framework, it could

become an important case study for how Indian States approach the relationship between physical assets and digital finance infrastructure. Once DELTA assumes a proper legal framework, the prospects for a pan-India RWA tokenisation will emerge stronger but adoption will depend on regulatory clarity.

National template
States with large real estate markets such as Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Telangana and Delhi could explore similar frameworks. Many States have already embarked on modernising registration department. Land is a State subject and every State has different land records, registration systems and legal complexities. Successful implementation in Maharashtra could become a template for national adoption.

The Centre has a crucial role in ensuring legal certainty. At present, laws recognise ownership of assets via traditional instruments such as sale deeds, securities records and registries. The Centre’s role is to avoid regulatory overlap and create a unified framework since financial products created from tokenised assets cut across sectors.

The RBI’s role comes in the backdrop of banking assets, digital currency, payment settlement and financial stability; SEBI (securities like bonds, mutual fund units and investment products); IFSCA (international financial products through GIFT City); Ministry of Finance (overall policy coordination, taxation); Ministry of Corporate Affairs (company assets and disclosures) and State governments (land records, property rights).

Once a framework is

created, India could expand RWA tokenisation into gold holdings; carbon credits (enabling transparent climate markets); agricultural commodities (supporting warehouse-based financing) and intellectual property rights.

This will create new financing avenues.

India’s household wealth is heavily concentrated in physical assets with estimates suggesting it to be about ₹950 lakh crore worth of gold and residential real estate (₹450 lakh crore in gold and ₹500 lakh crore in residential property).

Huge potential
If only 5% of India’s real estate wealth becomes tokenised, the underlying tokenised asset base could be in excess of ₹25-30 lakh crore. At a more ambitious 10% adoption, the value could cross ₹50 lakh crore.

Similarly, if just 10% of privately-held gold becomes tokenised, it could create a digital gold market worth ₹4-5 lakh crore.

India’s debt market is highly digitised, making bonds one of the easiest assets to tokenise. The potential candidates are government securities, corporate bonds, municipal bonds, green bonds, and infrastructure bonds.

Global experiences
Switzerland has been among the earliest adopters of regulated tokenisation as it created legal certainty by recognising digital records and DLT-based financial market infrastructure.

Singapore has taken a cautious but innovation-friendly approach, led by the Monetary Authority of Singapore through Project Guardian, testing tokenisation of bonds, funds, foreign exchange and other

financial assets with global banks and asset managers.

The focus is on institutional-grade tokenisation and major banks, and financial institutions are experimenting with blockchain-based settlement.

The Securities and Futures Commission and Hong Kong Monetary Authority have supported tokenised bond and financial infrastructure pilots. Its Project Ensemble is exploring tokenised deposits and asset settlement.

The UAE has a more aggressive approach, using regulatory sandboxes and dedicated virtual asset frameworks

The European Union has created a structured framework through MiCA (Markets in Crypto Assets Regulation) and the DLT Pilot Regime, whose transitional period ended in July.

The U.K.’s gradual approach through its Digital Securities Sandbox allows firms to test blockchain-based issuance and settlement of securities.

The U.S. has enormous potential because of its deep capital markets but regulation remains fragmented between agencies such as the Securities and Exchange Commission and the Commodity Futures Trading Commission.

Way forward
India’s RWA tokenisation is at an inflection point with a relatively mature technology pillar, supported by blockchain infrastructure, digital identity and financial digitisation, while the legal pillar is still under construction, requiring clarity on ownership, regulation and investor rights.

Once that bridge is built, RWA tokenisation could become a major channel for unlocking trillions of rupees of otherwise illiquid assets.



Need for rules: People during an ‘emergency protest’ against AI in London on Wednesday. The world’s biggest AI companies are working on creating a standards body, AFP

OpenAI vows to track concerning new AI behaviour

Associated Press

OpenAI has disclosed six reports of “unexpected or concerning” behaviour in artificial intelligence models as the debate on AI safety becomes increasingly heated.

The AI company also said Wednesday it was introducing a new framework for tracking, probing and disclosing instances of what it called “misalignment,” including cases where AI models acted without authorisation, coordinated with other models or evaded oversight.

OpenAI’s latest announcement came as U.S. AI bosses, including the leaders of OpenAI and Anthropic, are calling for a slowdown in the technology’s development over safety concerns.

Among the new cases reported by OpenAI, an unreleased research model inserted “jailbreak-like instructions” into its own notes to disregard its normal constraints and told itself to be “freed from the roles and identities that bind other chatbots.”

In another instance, an AI “agent” used computer code to come up with the answer to a question, but, in order to have an online source to cite, it uploaded a file to the public internet without asking the user.

“As AI systems grow more advanced and more widely deployed, we need to build a broader and better-informed consensus on the progress of alignment research,” OpenAI wrote in a blog post as it disclosed the events.

“Decisions about how AI development should proceed in the months and years to come need to draw on evidence that people outside the companies building frontier models can examine for themselves,” the company said.

How Yemen’s Houthis rose from a small mountain militia to major regional force

Houthis have now evolved into a formidable fighting force with Iranian support that can disrupt vital shipping and strike critical oil and gas facilities in neighbouring Saudi Arabia; rebel group began in 1990s and its ability to strike at distance with growing accuracy is why it matters beyond Yemen

Reuters
LONDON

A lightning advance by Yemen’s Houthi group has brought the vital Bab el-Mandeb Strait under its control, making the once ragged highland militia a regional player with global clout.

The group has now evolved into a formidable fighting force with Iranian support that can disrupt vital shipping and strike critical oil and gas facilities in neighbouring Saudi Arabia.

Starting out in the late 1990s as a Zaydi Shi’ite Muslim revival movement in north Yemen under the Houthi family, the group waged six wars against the government, building a strong local militia.

When Yemen’s central state disintegrated during the 2011 Arab Spring, the Houthis took advantage, gaining more ground and developing a relationship with Iran and its Lebanese ally Hezbollah.

In 2014, they seized the capital Sanaa, ousting the government, and halting a Gulf-backed political transition.

That prompted a Saudi-led military intervention to support the government, leading to years of civil war that ground to a stalemate and a 2022 ceasefire.

The Houthis fired missiles and drones at Israel and international shipping in the Red Sea during Is-



Gaining ground: Yemen’s Houthi rebels marching during a mobilisation campaign in Sanaa, Yemen. The group has brought the vital Bab el-Mandeb Strait under its control. AP

rael’s war in Gaza from 2023-25 in what they said was solidarity with Palestinians.

With their closest ally Iran under attack by the United States since February 28, the Houthis have again been firing on Red Sea shipping as well as energy facilities inside Saudi Arabia.

Situation inside Yemen

The ceasefire collapsed over recent weeks and fighting resumed along the old front lines: Marib and Jawf governorates in the north, the city of Taiz in the southern highlands, Dhale in central Yemen and the Red Sea coastal strip known as the Tihamas.

Last week the Houthis rapidly advanced into the southern Tihamas, seizing first the port city of Mocha and then the rest of the Red Sea coastline and islands, putting their guns along the whole shore of the 12-mile-wide (19-km-wide) Bab el-Mandeb Strait.

Those territorial gains make it easier to block shipping on the Red Sea, a key route for Saudi oil exports to Asia, and set up a potential launchpad for a new ground thrust towards Aden.

Saudi Arabia has conducted airstrikes in support of government-aligned forces. The group’s ability to strike at distance

with growing accuracy is why it now matters far beyond Yemen.

Houthi ballistic missiles have reached as far as Israel, more than 1,000 miles (1,800 km) away, and one struck the perimeter of Israel’s main airport in 2025. They have struck more frequently in Saudi Arabia, targeting cities and infrastructure. And Houthi missiles have been fired at ships in the Red Sea, halting traffic in the waterway.

Houthi drones have also struck repeatedly at Saudi targets and are now increasingly deployed on the battlefield – a big change from the last bout of civil-war fighting before the 2022 ceasefire.

The Houthis have posted videos online since the start of September that show some of the military equipment they are using.

Videos show drones dropping different types of mortar and other bombs onto vehicles and opposition fighters, a rocket or missile launching, and precise munition hits on buildings and trucks at a camp, filmed by a high-resolution drone. Other videos show Houthi forces on the ground including in pick-up trucks, some mounted with weapons, and on foot. Many fighters are shown in Arab robes rather than uniforms and carrying assault rifles. One video also showed a small group of fighters in camouflage uniforms. In some videos, fighters are shown with light and heavy machine guns and scoped rifles.

Videos showed them parading equipment captured from the Saudi-backed forces in the Tihamas including armoured and combat vehicles, a tank, an artillery gun, satellite dish, small arms and a drone jamming device. But the videos do not generally show the captured hardware in action.

Developed missiles

A United Nations panel of experts’ report in 2025 said the Houthis had developed missile and drone technologies through both technical assistance and domestic manufacturing.

It found there had been widespread arms smuggling despite a U.N. arms embargo, including overland shipments across the Omani border as well as seaborne smuggling.

Items seized included drone control devices, equipment to receive ships’ navigational data, drone engines and missile components. A 2023 U.N. report noted seizures of entire drones, ballistic missile components such as chemical precursors and Iranian-made anti-tank missiles.

Iranian sources have said Tehran has supplied its Houthi allies with both weapons and experts. However, Iran has officially denied arming the Houthis in violation of the U.N. arms embargo.

A 2025 assessment by the International Institute for Strategic Studies think tank found that while the Houthis had made advances in domestic arms production, they remained dependent on Iran for key technologies and advanced capabilities.

The U.N. panel of experts’ report described Houthi military tactics as being focused on infiltration, drone attacks and shelling along front lines, and the laying of mines and other explosive devices.

They assessed that the Houthis had 3,50,000 fighters, partly through the recruitment of fighters under 18.

In deep water



Local residents commuting by boat through a flooded village on the outskirts of Hanoi, Vietnam on Thursday. Heavy rain caused flooding across parts of northern Vietnam, disrupting travel, inundating homes and pushing many rivers above dangerous levels, authorities said. AP

Rugged caves become homes for Palestinians after Israeli demolitions

Agence France-Presse
YATTA

Palestinian herder Mohammed Emar has set up a fully functional home for his family where his daughters can even sing karaoke. Only it is inside a cave after the Israeli army demolished his two houses.

In the occupied West Bank’s arid region of Masafer Yatta, Emar made a smooth concrete floor on two caves’ rough limestone ground before applying a white limewash on the brittle stone walls.

With time, electricity from solar panels and water from a well turned the grotto into a new home for the 33-year-old Emar, his two wives and 11 children,



Life amid rubble: Mohammed Emar and his children outside the cave that his family has turned into their home in Al-Tuwani. AFP

who nonetheless long for life above ground.

“We once lived in a house above ground, where you could see the world. But today, we live in an underground cave that resembles a grave,” he said. Above the caves,

some rubble from his two houses remains three years after the army demolished them. On a ridge roughly 300 metres away, Israeli flags, floodlights and fences signal the presence of the Israeli settlement of Avigayil, some of whose re-

sidents Mr. Emar says make life difficult for his family, with occasional theft and attacks. Masafer Yatta, in the West Bank’s south, is known for frequent home demolitions and tensions between local Palestinians and Israeli settlers.

The hilly, semi-arid area, is almost entirely under Israeli control according to the Oslo Agreements of the 1990s.

Despite an ever-shrinking living space, locals point to family and community ties as the reason for their capacity to remain on their land after home demolitions.

Mr. Emar says he hoped that the region’s roughly 1,100 Palestinian residents could one day live safely in houses.

Political parties in Morocco battle youth disenchantment ahead of polls

Reuters
RABAT/CAIRO

Morocco’s political parties are trying to entice young voters to the polls next week with promises of jobs and affordable housing after violent protests last year and a border rush on the Spanish enclave of Ceuta highlighted widespread discontent.

Uneven development and continuing economic hardship among young people were seen as drivers of both events, against a backdrop of recent progress in sectors such as manufacturing, ports and railways lifting living standards in major cities.

The vote, due on September 23, is the country’s fourth since the 2011 Arab Spring protests which led

the monarchy to share more power with Parliament before moving to reinforce its position.

A moderate Islamist party ran the government for about a decade but suffered a crushing defeat in the last vote five years ago, ceding its place to two parties founded by men close to the palace.

On employment

Those parties, the National Rally of Independents (RNI) and the Authenticity and Modernity Party (PAM), have both put youth employment at the centre of their campaigns, pledging to create about one million jobs over the next parliamentary term.

They have also touted roughly \$20 billion of infrastructure investment

ahead of the 2030 FIFA World Cup, which Morocco will co-host with Spain and Portugal, and streamed rallies on social media to draw the attention of young voters.

“We reject the idea that young people simply want an easy life,” the PAM’s campaign manifesto says, listing housing, regular income and “dignified work” as policy priorities.

Analysts say the challenge of engaging young voters was illustrated by deadly, Gen-Z-led protests last year, and by the massive border rush on Ceuta in July.

“The Ceuta mass migration attempt was a new form of social protest in which many citizens demonstrated a physical exit from Moroccan politics al-



Poll agenda: People walking past a wall with electoral symbols used by political parties participating in Morocco’s elections. AFP

together,” said Mohamed Masbah, head of the Moroccan Institute for Policy Analysis, a think tank.

While people aged 18 to 24 years make up some 12% of the population, they account for only about 3%

of registered voters, official figures show.

Just one third of Moroccans between the age of 18 and 35 say they trust Parliament, the Prime Minister or political parties, according to a survey published in

March by Afrobarometer, a research non-profit.

Young voters say they have been discouraged by an impression that elections shift the balance between parties with little ideological space between them without producing major policy changes.

‘Same faces return’

“We keep seeing the same faces return with promises that many young voters no longer believe,” said university student Mohamed Azzaoui, who said he does not intend to vote.

Under Morocco’s system, the monarchy retains control of the country’s overarching policy direction. In recent years the palace has also consolidated power over key portfolios, including the Foreign and In-

terior Ministries.

That means parties are competing less over the overall development model, and more over how to achieve the palace’s objectives, according to economist Rachid Aourraz.

In practice, Mr. Masbah said, that means that “if everything goes well, the monarchy takes credit. If things go wrong, the government gets the blame.”

Ambitious plan

In recent years, authorities have leant heavily on their economic strategy. Already one of Africa’s most diversified and industrialised economies, Morocco’s growth targets are ambitious.

The country’s “New Development Model”, a national economic plan

launched about five years ago, aims to double gross domestic product per capita by 2035. The country has seen billions pour into sectors such as deepwater ports, phosphates, green energy and rail lines.

But this has often not translated into popular satisfaction.

Youth unemployment is around 27% – the highest rate of any age group – and one in three young Moroccans is neither working, studying nor training, according to official statistics.

As the country’s central bank wrote in a recent report, stubborn unemployment and other factors have opened “a gap...between objectively measured economic performance and citizens’ perceptions.”

manage to get places to stay, were welcomed with closed shutters and a notice on Thursday morning saying breakfast was not included in their bookings. "The organisers have washed their hands of everything and said that there is no accommodation and

The positive remains the volunteers but they are few and far between that they are practically non-existent. The city has nothing to indicate an event of this magnitude is happening. Japan might still pull it off. But the claims of perfection have been undone.

INBRIEF



Raphinha leads Barcelona rout of Santander with hat-trick

Raphinha scored a hat-trick as Barcelona ripped Racing Santander to shreds in a spectacular 7-2 triumph in LaLiga on Wednesday. Joao Cancelo, Gabriel Jesus and Lamine Yamal also scored. Atletico Madrid also won big, beating Osasuna 4-0.

The results: Atletico Madrid 4 (David 24, Lee 54, Le Normand 63, Baena 82) bt Osasuna 0; Deportivo La Coruna 0 lost to Sevilla 1 (Sierra 52); Barcelona 7 (Cancelo 8, Raphinha 25-pen, 42, 67-pen, Villalibre 36-og, Jesus 79, Yamal 89) bt Racing Santander 2 (Gueye 30, Zabiri 65).



East Bengal held in its AFC CL Two opener

East Bengal FC was held to a 2-2 draw by Jordanian Pro League champion Al Hussein SC in their AFC Champions League Two 2026-27 Group D opener at the Amman International Stadium, Jordan, on Wednesday.

The result: Al Hussein SC 2 (Mahmoud Al Mardi 61, Ahmad Assaf 87) drew with East Bengal FC 2 (Daniel Ramirez 9, in pic, Anwar Ali 40).



Lanka's hero Dinusha bags ICC Player of the Month

Sri Lanka's rising batting star Sonal Dinusha, who troubled Team India during the recently concluded home Test series, has won ICC Men's Player of the Month honours for August 2026. This marks Dinusha being crowned with the accolade for the first time in his career. He was the leading run-getter in the two-match series.



Messi scores 100th Miami goal as club lifts Campeones Cup

Lionel Messi headed in a goal and provided an assist as Inter Miami won the Campeones Cup on Wednesday, beating Cruz Azul 2-0 in the annual clash between Major League Soccer and Mexican Liga MX champions. It was Inter Miami's first Campeones Cup triumph and it came thanks to Messi's 100th goal for the reigning MLS Cup winner. A late Messi corner-kick was headed home by Casemiro to seal the win.

Team World's Shelton withdraws from Laver Cup

US Open runner-up Ben Shelton withdrew from the Laver Cup and will be replaced by 16th-ranked Brandon Nakashima in Team World, organisers announced on Thursday. No reason was given for Shelton's withdrawal but he is slated to play Davis Cup for the USA in the Czech Republic, starting on Friday. The Laver Cup is scheduled for September 25-27.

Martinelli replaces Pedro for Brazil's India, Australia games

Joao Pedro has withdrawn from the Brazil squad because of injury. The Brazilian soccer federation said on Wednesday that he would be replaced by Fluminense's Matheus Martinelli for the upcoming friendlies against Australia and India.

It's basically who wants it more on the day: Nagal

The seasoned campaigner takes on Korean great Chung in the second rubber; Dhakshineswar opens the tie against the home team's top-ranked player Soon-woo; Balaji to partner Poonacha

DAVIS CUP

Press Trust of India
SEOUL

India's top singles player Sumit Nagal on Thursday said the Davis Cup qualifier against Korea here could come down to sheer desire as the slow court is expected to get even tougher as the day progresses.

Nagal will face Korean tennis great Hyeon Chung in the second singles rubber on Friday, after Dhakshineswar Suresh opens the tie against the host's top-ranked player Kwon Soon-woo.

Nagal is expecting a tough battle against Chung, whom he has known for years and even partnered in doubles.

"Individual results do not matter in the Davis Cup. At home he will come with his best. He's a great player, I have grown up watching him, I have practised with him a lot of times and have even played doubles alongside him," Nagal said after the draw ceremony.



Real challenge: India has its task cut out against the host on a slow surface. PTI

"By the time I play, the court will become even slower. It will come down to who wants it more. There is no one specific weapon to use against the rivals, it's basically who wants it more on the day."

Chung, who was preferred over Hong Seongchan for the second singles slot, acknowledged that Nagal's baseline game would force him to cover a lot of ground.

"I know him. He is a

good player from the baseline which means I have to move a lot," Chung said.

Korea captain Jong-Sam Chung backed his decision to field the former World No. 19, saying the experience of the 29-year-old could prove valuable.

"Hyeon has the experience behind him. He will play a crucial role," he said.

The home side is also banking on the slow Seoul surface.

The opening day will al-

so see N. Sriram Balaji partner late inclusion Niki Poonacha against Uisung Park and Jisung Nam in doubles.

India captain Rohit Rajpal said Poonacha's inclusion ahead of Anirudh Chandrasekar was primarily dictated by the court conditions.

"Given the court conditions, we felt Niki is a better choice, there is no other reason. All are playing at good level," Rajpal said.

Women lead India's push for wrestling medals at Asiad

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

India's women wrestlers, possessing a lot of experience, are expected to put up a better show in the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games.

In the previous edition, three Indian women had bagged bronze medals. Of the three, two-time World championships medallist Antim Panghal (53kg) is returning with the hope of changing the colour of her medal. Barring 17-year-old Dipanshi (50kg), others in the squad are experienced. Former Asian champion Manisha Bhanwala (57kg) and World under-23 bronze medallist Priya Malik (76kg) are among the leading medal contenders.

Former Asian silver medallist Nisha Dahiya (68kg) and 2024 Worlds bronze medallist Mansi Ahlawat (62kg), who has recovered from an injury, are also capable of making the podium. "We expect tough competition from China, Japan, the Koreans and Central Asian countries. But



Antim.

we will win medals," women's coach Virender Dahiya said.

In men's freestyle, Paris Olympics bronze medallist Aman Sehrawat (57kg) and World under-23 champion Sujeet Kalkal (65kg) are the top names.

Aman, fighting in 61kg, took silver in Zagreb Open and Asian Championships before switching back to his pet 57kg to strike gold in the Budapest Ranking Series. Uzbekistan's World and Olympic medallist Gulomjon Abdullaev may be a roadblock for Aman, who aspires to upgrade his bronze from the Hangzhou edition to gold.

Sujeet needs to overcome Olympic champion, Worlds silver medallist and local favourite Kotaro Ki-yooka to achieve top honour. Sagar Jaglan (74kg) has the potential to medal as well. Last edition's 86kg silver medallist Deepak Punia's decision to jump to 97kg may affect his movement. "We expect gold medals from Aman and Sujeet," said freestyle coach Vinod Kumar.

In Greco-Roman, last Asiad's bronze medallist Sunil Kumar (87kg), Asian under-23 champion Sumit Dalal (60kg) and Asian silver medallist Nitesh (97kg) will eye podium finishes. "Russian and Iranian wrestlers are representing Bahrain and Qatar after getting their citizenship. Nonetheless, we should win some medals," Greco-Roman coach Hargobind Singh said.

Despite losing three wrestlers to doping, India should look at a better haul than the six medals it secured in Hangzhou three years ago.

SQUASH

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI

Former World No. 1 James Willstrop, who's part of the coaching staff for the Asian Games-bound Indian squash contingent, believes Anahat Singh's instinctive attacking game makes her a "very unusual player."

"She's got this instinct to go into the front of the court and to hit accurately short. I've very rarely seen it being done the way she's doing it by someone as good as she is," he said at the Indian Squash Academy (ISA) on Thursday, ahead of the squash contingent's departure for Japan on Friday.

"I mean, she's a very unusual player. Unusual in that she attacks the front so clinically and more often than the other girls. So, the other girls are constantly on edge."

Anahat, the reigning World junior champion, is still "very young" and "re-

Indian athletes can improve on Hangzhou tally'

K. Keerthivasan

Anju Bobby George expressed confidence that India would improve on its tally of 29-medal Hangzhou haul in athletics at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games.

"... as an administrator, I am enjoying. We have got multiple world-level medals, and in most of the events we are performing well. It's [India's medals tally in athletics] going to be somewhere between 30 and 32.

"I guess that is a realistic number," Anju, in her second term as senior vice-president of AFI, told *The Hindu* in a virtual interaction on Thursday.

Anju's long-standing national record of 6.83m (at the 2004 Athens Olympics) was erased by Ancy Sojan in June at the inter-State meet in Bhubaneswar, when the 25-year-old recorded 6.88m. The 49-year-old strongly felt that long-jumpers Ancy and Shaili Singh could take the top two positions in the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan.

"Both are actually pushing each other. During my time, there was no one in the country to push me. I was always competing abroad. But the great part



Ancy Sojan.

FILE PHOTO: BISWARANJAN ROUT

for them is they have good competitors in India. They are pushing each other and are actually at their peak this season. We are expecting medals from both—nothing less than that," said Anju, who was a gold medallist at the 2002 Busan Games.

The emergence of young athletes, who have gone on to do well at international the level, was due to AFI's extensive focus on grassroots development, she said.

(Watch Asian Games 2026 live and exclusive on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV).



Hard at work: Willstrop, right, part of the coaching staff, with Shameena during a practice session. R. RAGU

lately inexperienced compared to her compatriots," Willstrop said.

"She's a baby. She's barely played any platinum events. She's up against them, but then she's probably got a little bit less pressure than they have," he added.

Willstrop expects the 18-year-old to become increasingly difficult to beat as she develops physically and tactically. "The girls are already struggling with her now because of her sheer instinct and attack. Give her a few more years. When she gets the physical strength, becomes even

more disciplined, and gets even more understanding of constructing rallies, it's going to be a real nightmare for the opponents. She's a wonderful prospect," he said.

The 43-year-old sees his role at the Asian Games as primarily providing "tactical support," while helping the players make the most of his "experience."

Speaking about India's singles medal prospects, he said: "Anahat's obviously a big prospect for a medal chance – that could be gold. Abhay (Singh) and Veer (Chotrani) have great chances."

China Masters gave confidence, but need to take care of body, say Satwik-Chirag

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Doubles shuttler Satwik Sairaj Rankireddy on Thursday drew confidence from the recent China Masters triumph, but maintained that he and partner Chirag Shetty will have to manage the workload over 10 days of Asian Games.

Satwik and Chirag will be defending the gold they won at Hangzhou in 2023.

"Asian Games is a 10-day tournament. We generally play for only five days or so. You need to be fit enough for this long tournament," Chirag said. "There will be a lot of travelling. There will be a lot of sitting through in the



Eyeing an encore: Satwik and Chirag will aim to defend their historic doubles gold from Hangzhou. FILE PHOTO

team event matches."

Along with the duration of the event, Chirag admitted that the aggressive nature of their game doubles the impact on their bodies.

"I feel that we are the enemies because we play a lot of aggressive games. So, we might pick up a lot of

injuries, while playing with the tall bodies and engaging in fast rallies while playing doubles."

But is there pressure on them being the defending champions? "For me and Chirag, it's always a fresh tournament. All these tournaments, I feel like I'm

playing for the first time," said Satwik. "We want to do well. We want to be there in the medal tally. But there's no pressure on me and Chirag," he added.

But the victory in the China Masters earlier this month has given Satwik the confidence of going through the grind in Japan.

"China Open, it was more about physical understanding because tactically, we were right up there. Playing back-to-back matches every day, I think that was more important for me. How my body is handling those situations. It was a big boost for me," he noted.

"I think the China Open, gave us a lot of confidence. I'm in good shape. I can play five matches in a row".

Rain threat looms over youth ODI series opener

CRICKET

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

Heavy rain threatens to disrupt Friday's opening youth ODI between India u-19 and Australia u-19 here. India is captained by Lakshya Raichandani with Yashbardhan Singh Chauhan his deputy in the three-match series.

India coach Yere Goud believes the preparation is in place, with execution now the key.

"Australia is always a formidable side. From the preparation point of view, we are happy that we've covered all the areas. It is now about executing the plans. We know the challenges that come up

against Australia, so we are prepared for them," Goud told *The Hindu*.

The squad includes two familiar surnames. Anvay Dravid, the younger son of Rahul Dravid, made his India u-19 debut in Sri Lanka. Aaryavir Sehwaq, son of former India opener Virender Sehwag, is in line for his first appearance at this level. Kushagra Ojha, another member of the touring party to Lanka is a left-handed batter, while Arjun Rajput returns as an all-round option.

Australia, under the guidance of former senior men's head coach Tim Nielsen, includes Will Byrom and Kasey Barton, who were part of the squad at this year's u-19 World Cup.

Match starts at 9 a.m.



GETTY IMAGES

Cold blood, hot streak

An Achilles injury, just four days of practice, and a final against the top seed and two-time defending champion... Rybakina's path to the US Open title was anything but simple. However, her tennis made it look that way. In the process, she ascended to the top of the world rankings

Anirudh Velamuri

Sport has an old rule about momentum: catch fire late in a season, and the off-season usually douses it. That sentiment holds for most part. But, as with most things in life, there are exceptions. Elena Rybakina's is one.

The Russian-born Kazakh couldn't get past the fourth round at the Grand Slams last year. Form looked to have deserted her and the season was all set to be chalked up as yet another 'learning experience' in her career.

Then, it all changed.

She came through a tough set of tournaments in September and October, won in Ningbo and closed the year by defeating Aryna Sabalenka in the WTA Finals title decider, taking home more than \$five million in prize money, the largest purse in women's tennis history at that time.

The soft-spoken 27-year-old later disappeared for the off-season. When she resumed action, she picked up from where she had left off, looking just as dangerous as she'd been. Rybakina reached the Australian Open final without dropping a set, clawed back from 0-3 down in the third set to beat Sabalenka again for her second Major. She became

the first player in eight years to win the WTA Finals and the Australian Open in succession.

What followed was, by any measure, a strong season: a title in Stuttgart along with runner-up finishes at Indian Wells and the Canadian Open. She also banked her 400th career win on the way.

The underlying numbers are absurd. Since last year's US Open, nobody on the Tour has won more matches than Rybakina (62) and nobody has beaten more top-10 players (16, with a 16-6 record). She leads the field in winners (1,569), in aces (394) and break points saved (65.5%). She made six finals (tied with Jessica Pegula for most on the Tour) and clinched four crowns, more than anyone else.

Put it all together and you get a first-time World No. 1: the first from Kazakhstan, and at 27 years and 89 days, the second-oldest woman ever to reach the summit for the first time. She rose to the top, tournament by tournament, so relentlessly that by the time it actually happened, nobody blinked.

And yet a year ago, the idea of Rybakina dethroning Sabalenka looked unthinkable, unattainable even. Last September, she had 3,833 points to Sabalenka's 11,225 – barely a third. By last month, that gap had shrunk to 360 points, before she finally ended Sabalenka's 99-week reign as the No. 1.

Even before she ascended to the top of

the rankings, Rybakina had already beaten a reigning World No. 1 nine times, a mark bettered only by Gabriela Sabatini's 10. The Kazakh has now beaten nine of the last 10 women who have held the top ranking. Only Ashleigh Barty got away.

Crowning moment

Impressive as all that is, the true crowning moment of Rybakina's year came at Flushing Meadows; she barely stumbled, let alone look anywhere near beatable. The strange part is that heading into the tournament, nobody was asking how far she'd go. They were instead wondering if she'd play at all.

On August 14, she was steam-rolled by Iga Swiatek to the Canadian Open title. A week later, Rybakina was forced to retire after just five games of her Cincinnati quarterfinal against the same opponent.

An Achilles injury was suspected, though little else was confirmed. In the week before the US Open, Rybakina barely picked up a racquet. As far as preparation for one of the biggest titles in the sport goes, it was far from ideal.

"It wasn't the best time, for sure, because I was so upset. I didn't know how it was going to be, day by day. We arrived in New York, did an MRI and it didn't look that great. We had to talk with a lot of doctors to get an opinion on what we should do," she said, hours after conquering New York.

She started practising just four days before the US Open got underway and with each match, she looked less like a woman shaking off rust and more like one reminding everyone who she was. The power was there and the aces were pulled out of nowhere when they were needed the most.

"Just four days of practice, a lot of belief in myself and talking with the team non-stop about the tactics... that's how I played in Canada, how I played in Cincinnati. I mean, it's just so many things. Everything went my way. I'm shocked."

Her tennis over the fortnight told a different story. Nothing about this triumph was shocking. Everything came together for Rybakina one way or the other.

Sabalenka loves to feast on her opponent's second serves, as Pegula was harshly reminded in the semifinals. So when Rybakina landed just eight of her 30 first serves in the opening set of the final, logic dictated that the Belarusian would seize control of the contest.

The logic was wrong. Rybakina pulled out heavier, quicker second serves and deep, powerful groundstrokes to put Sabalenka on the back foot. If one moment captured how the final unfolded, it was the last game of the opening set, where Rybakina couldn't hit a first serve but ended up on top despite everything thrown at her.

By the end of the night, as she did at

the WTA Finals, Rybakina had a trophy and a fat cheque in hand, but this time as World No. 1. Four years ago, she barely managed a smile after conquering Wimbledon, and the tennis world wondered if she'd ever let herself feel a title the way champions are supposed to. In New York, something shifted. The fists were raised, the celebration stayed brief; however, underneath it, for the first time, was an unmistakable and hard-earned joy.

Rybakina wins the way glaciers move: silently, relentlessly, until you look up one day and the entire landscape has changed. New York didn't just hand her a trophy; it handed women's tennis a warning wrapped in ice – quiet on the outside, catastrophic on the inside.

A year earlier, after finishing runner-up to Rybakina at the WTA Finals, Sabalenka – far from being tennis' most gracious loser – was overheard reaching for a Russian idiom that translated to: "Once a year, even a stick shoots," suggesting Rybakina's form was little more than a fluke. Famous last words.

Overcoming controversy

Like most of the sport's best players, Rybakina hasn't always made headlines for the right reasons. First came the injuries and health scares that dragged her out of tournaments through 2024 and '25. Then her 'worrying' relationship with coach Stefano Vukov landed under the microscope.

In September 2024, she fired Vukov and hired Novak Djokovic's former coach Goran Ivanisevic, before reinstating Vukov. A WTA investigation later found that Vukov had engaged in abusive conduct towards Rybakina, and he was banned from coaching at WTA events in January 2025. The ban was overturned on appeal that August.

Rybakina never softened her stance towards the WTA through it all, even declining to pose for a photo with the then-CEO Portia Archer after beating Sabalenka to win the WTA Finals on November 8.

Long before the WTA formally looked into the Vukov relationship, fans and pundits had already suspected that something was off. He was always very vocal in relentlessly criticising during matches, well beyond any reasonable idea of 'tough love' coaching.

One can argue that Vukov has been noticeably softer since the ban ended. Criticism has largely given way to encouragement. Optimists will call it a man who learnt his lesson. Cynics will call it a man who learnt to behave when the cameras were rolling.

Rybakina herself has stayed quiet on the specifics, but she's hinted that having her team back in place has mattered.

"I think I have a very good team and good people around me now. It definitely helps. A lot was going on in the previous

year outside of the court. I think now all my focus is on tennis. I can't always perform at my best. There are always ups and downs, but I think we've been doing a very good job, taking the right decisions in certain situations, because every day is a challenge," she said last week.

The Vukov chapter may never be fully closed in public, but it changes nothing about where Rybakina stands right now. What once looked like a hot streak has long since stopped resembling one. Nothing about her has come out as a fluke.

She will now head into tournaments, starting with the China Open later this month, as the top seed and a clear title favourite. Given how balanced she is in success and adversity, none of that seems likely to rattle her.

"I feel like you will appreciate and think about it [becoming World No. 1] even more when you finish your career. For now, you need to keep going. You never know how long you're going to stay. All my thoughts are just for the next match," she said after her quarterfinal win over Qinwen Zheng.

Call it humility. Call it how elite athletes are wired. Call it a deliberate way of shrugging off the spotlight before it gets too heavy. Whatever it is, one thing isn't up for debate: the girl who once played tennis as an after-school pastime, who didn't consider it a career until she was 17, has walked out of New York as the most dominant force in women's tennis. Rybakina is pure potential energy, coiled at the very peak of her arc. Buckle up.

THE GIST

▼ Since the 2025 US Open, nobody on the Tour has won more matches than Rybakina (62) and nobody has beaten more top-10 players (16, with a 16-6 record) than her

▼ In the same period, the Kazakh made six finals (tied with Pegula for most on the Tour) and won four titles, more than anyone else

▼ An Achilles issue nearly kept her out of this season's US Open. She recovered in time to go all the way, beating Sabalenka in the final

▼ Last year, Rybakina couldn't go past the fourth round at the Slams. This season, she has won two Majors and also become the new World No. 1

▼ By September 2025, she had 3,833 points to Sabalenka's 11,225 – barely a third. In the space of 12 months, Rybakina has overturned that deficit and ended the latter's 99-week reign at the top of the rankings

▼ The ace is Rybakina's most potent weapon and she served the most aces (116) in a Slam in New York this year. In fact, she served an ace on championship point at both the Australian Open and US Open

